

Urdu, Step by Step, Root by Root

A gentle, etymology-driven introduction to contemporary Urdu

Adhithya Rajasekaran

Starter edition — fifteen short chapters, with more being written.

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Preface

This book teaches Urdu one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart. It assumes no Urdu and no Perso-Arabic script: every section takes one small expression, introduces only the letters, sounds, and grammar that expression needs, connects it to words you may already know, and ends by asking for it back. Urdu reads right to left — but you will be reading real words long before you have met the whole alphabet.

Urdu makes several histories visible at once. Its grammar and much of its everyday vocabulary are Indo-Aryan, closely related to Hindi, while Persian and Arabic have contributed a large literary and formal layer on top. Etymology in this book is a memory aid — never a claim that a borrowed word is any less fully Urdu today.

Urdu is traditionally printed in the flowing, descending *Nastaliq* style. This edition uses the vendored Noto Nastaliq Urdu family, so the script’s diagonal word shape and joining behaviour reproduce identically in local and published builds. The book keeps romanization beside each new form while the script becomes familiar.

This is a starter edition: fifteen short chapters, complete in themselves, with more being written.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Urdu out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

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Chapter 1

Greetings and responses

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 👁️ eyes (2) ✍️ pen (1) 🖱️ **Hands-free start:** first 1 of 5 lessons.

This chapter builds one miniature exchange in dependency order: greet, trace three shapes, finish and copy “thank you,” answer yes, answer no. Every step stays under five minutes. The first writing step stops after recognition and tracing; guided copying begins only after all five shapes are familiar.

1.1 سلام (*salām*) — hello through peace

Read only what this expression needs

Urdu runs **right to left**. Read سلام from its right edge: س *s*, ل *l*, ا *ā*, م *m*. Letters usually join inside a word. The tall *ā* does not connect to the following letter, so the final *m* begins a new stroke group. No other letters are due yet.

Where the expression came from

Salām is a greeting and the word “peace.” Urdu received it through the Persian-Arabic literary world. Its consonants **s–l–m** belong to a Semitic family concerned with peace, safety, and wholeness. Persian *salām*, Arabic *salām*, and Hebrew *shalom* make the historical family especially visible.

Use it now

Say سلام to begin a friendly exchange. For now the safest reply is the same word: A says سلام; B answers سلام. One useful move is enough.

One-minute checkpoint

Read سلام from right to left. Which letter carries long *ā*? Point to *l*, cover the romanization, and say *salām* once.

1.2 ش ک ر — three shapes, then stop

Read only what this expression needs

Take only three shapes from the spoken word *shukriyā*: ش *sh* with three dots above, ک *k* with its long inner slash, and ر *r* as a falling curve. Read them right to left once: ر ش ک. The joined word and its final two shapes wait for the next short lesson.

Use it now

Trace ش, ک, and ر once each while looking at the models. Pause before the three dots of ش and before the separate slash of ک. Do not join the shapes and do not write from memory yet.

One-minute checkpoint

Point in this order and say the sounds: *sh*, *k*, *r*. Stop after three.

1.3 شکرِیہ (shukriyā) — thank you

Read only what this expression needs

Urdu normally leaves short vowels unmarked. Reuse ش, ک, and ر; then add only ی *y/i* and final ہ. The learned whole supplies the short *u* and *i*, while the ending is pronounced long *ā*. This step therefore asks for two new shapes, not five.

Where the expression came from

The central consonants **sh–k–r** belong to the Arabic family for gratitude; Arabic *shukran* is a close comparison. Urdu *shukriyā* reflects its long Persian-Arabic lexical history and is an ordinary modern Urdu expression.

Use it now

Build a two-step chain: سلام *salām* — hello; شکرِیہ *shukriyā* — thank you. Keep the second word in three light beats: *shuk-ri-yā*.

Use it now

Copy شکرِیہ once while keeping the model visible. Say *shukriyā* after the pen stops. Writing from memory can wait.

One-minute checkpoint

Which two shapes did this lesson add? Point to ی and final ہ, then say *salām* — *shukriyā*. One model-visible copy is enough.

1.4 جی ہاں (*jī hā*) — yes, respectfully

Read only what this expression needs

This answer has two small words. In جی, ج gives *j* and ی stretches the vowel to *ī*. In ہاں, the final ں is **nūn ghunna**: it nasalizes long *ā* rather than adding a strong English *n*. Let a little air pass through the nose.

Use it now

ہاں means “yes.” Adding جی makes the response attentive and respectful; جی can also answer by itself. Learn the safely courteous whole first: جی ہاں *jī hā*.

One-minute checkpoint

Which final sign nasalizes the vowel? Point to ں. Then answer politely: جی ہاں.

1.5 نہیں (*nahī*) — no, and later not

Read only what this expression needs

Reuse ہ, ی, and nasal ں; add ن *n* at the right edge. The result is نہیں *nahī*. Stretch *ī* slightly and nasalize it; do not add a separate forceful *n* at the end.

Where the expression came from

Unlike the Persian-Arabic vocabulary that opened the chapter, *nahī* belongs to Urdu’s inherited Indo-Aryan core. Hindi *nahī* is the same spoken word written in a different script. The shared form previews close grammatical kinship without making Hindi script a prerequisite.

Use it now

As a complete answer, **نہیں** means “no.” Inside a later sentence it will also mean “not,” but that second job can wait. Contrast only: **جی ہاں** — yes; **نہیں** — no.

One-minute checkpoint

Without looking back, produce the chain hello, thank you, yes, no.
Then read **نہیں**, **جی ہاں**, **شکریہ**, **سلام** in the same order.

Chapter 2

Give your name

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say my name in Urdu in one sentence, keeping hai at the end where Urdu puts it.

One sentence with a slot for your own name: merā nām ... hai, with the copula held to the end of the line.

2.1 میرا نام ... ہے — my name is ...

Greet once, then answer yes and no. The next line gives you one reliable Urdu sentence for your own name.

The exchange

Read the line right to left, but keep its spoken order:

میرا | نام | ... | ہے — merā nām ... hai

- میرا merā = my
- نام nām = name
- your name goes in the open slot
- ہے hai = is

The word **nām** is an old Indo-Aryan relative of Sanskrit *nāman* and distant English *name*. **merā** and **hai** show Urdu’s inherited grammatical core, shared closely with Hindi even though the two languages use different scripts.

Nearly every shape here is one you have already met. میرا opens with م, the letter that begins *salām*, then reuses ی, ر and ا. نام is ن plus that same ا and م. Only the final ے in ہے is new — it is called *barī ye*, the “big ye”, and here the whole word is said *hai*. Learn that vowel with this word and you will meet it again everywhere.

Grammar Lens: the verb waits

Urdu puts **hai** at the end. That is the only sentence-pattern fact to learn now: **my + name + NAME + is**. Keep this one frame; broader word-order and agreement rules can wait.

Your turn

ہے۔ سارا نام میرا — *merā nām Sārā hai*. — My name is Sara.

Replace **Sārā** with your own name. Do not add agreement rules yet; this exact frame is enough for the introduction.

Before you move on

Where does “is” go in this Urdu sentence? At the end. Say the four slots, then say the full sentence with your name.

Chapter 3

Ask and Answer Names

Modes: ⇐ voice (4) ⇐ eyes (1) ⇐ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask someone’s name with respectful āp, answer with my own, and close the introduction politely.

A six-line first meeting: greet, ask āp kā nām kyā hai?, answer with your own name, and close with āp se mil kar khushī huī.

3.1 آپ / تم / تو — three relationships inside “you”

Say **nahī** once, then **merā nām ... hai** with your own name.
To ask the other person’s name, begin with the respectful form.

You’ll want to know first — three forms

Urdu	read	use
آپ	āp	respectful: a new adult, elder, or anyone you wish to honor
تم	tum	familiar: friends and peers
تو	tū	intimate, or downward; unsafe as a beginner default

آپ begins with آ, an alif carrying the long ā mark, then پ p. تم and تو share ت t. In و, و carries long ū.

Grammar Lens: choose the relationship first

English flattened these choices into one *you*. Urdu keeps three. Use **āp** in a first meeting. Move to **tum** when the relationship supports familiarity. Save **tū** for relationships where you already know it is welcome; used badly, it can sound belittling.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Tum/tū belong to the old Indo-European familiar-“you” family: Sanskrit *tvam*, English **thou**, and Latin *tū* are relatives. **Āp** followed another route: a word connected with “self/oneself” became honorific address.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- a new adult — **āp**
- a friend — **tum**
- the old family — **tum**, **tvam**, **thou**

Before you move on

Which form is safest when unsure? (**Āp**.) Which familiar forms share history with English *thou*? (**Tum/tū**.)

Source: *Basic Urdu*: Cultural Notes.

3.2 کیا — what

Which “you” opens a respectful first meeting? (آپ, āp.) Now add the question word.

You'll want to know first — کیا

کیا — *kyā* — what

Read right to left: ک *k*, ی supplying the *y* glide here, then / long *ā*.
The same ی carried long *ī* in جی and نہیں. Its job depends on the word; here the learned shape is *kyā*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Urdu **kyā** and Hindi **kyā** are the same inherited Indo-Aryan word in different scripts. Their history reaches Sanskrit *kim* and the old Indo-European *k/kw-* question family behind English **wh-** words such as *what*, *who*, and *which*. The bridge helps memory; Urdu کیا remains the form you must read here.

Your turn

- Say it: **kyā** — what
- Read it: کیا as **k** + **yā**
- Say it: the family — **kyā**, **what**, **who**, **which**

Before you move on

Which letter acts as *y* here but as long *ī* in جی? (ی.) What does کیا mean? (**What**.)

3.3 ہے؟ کیا نام کا آپ — ask a name respectfully

Recall **āp** “you,” **kyā** “what,” and the answer **merā nām ... hai**. The question reuses all three.

The exchange

آپ کا نام کیا ہے؟ — *āp kā nām kyā hai?* — **What is your name?**

Build it in spoken order:

you + **kā** + name + what + is?

Āp kā means “your” in this frame. The possessive form agrees with the thing owned: **nām** is masculine singular, so use **kā**. Keep that one pairing; the full *kā/kī/ke* system can wait. As in your answer, **hai** stays at the end.

Script: the question mark

Urdu ends the question with ؟, curved for a right-to-left line. Begin at آپ on the right and reach the punctuation at the far left.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **āp kā nām kyā hai?**
- *Say it:* ask, then answer — **merā nām ... hai**
- *Point to:* to ؟ at the end

Before you move on

Ask once without romanization. Where does **hai** remain? (At the end.)

Source: *Basic Urdu: Greetings and Introductions*.

3.4 ہوئی خوشی کر مل سے آپ — pleased to meet you

Say the opening ladder once: **shukriyā — jī hā — nahī**. Point to the three shapes you traced before the joined thank-you word. Then ask **āp kā nām kyā hai?** and answer **merā nām ... hai**.

The exchange

آپ سے مل کر خوشی ہوئی۔ *āp se mil kar khushī huī* Pleased to meet you.

For now, hold three meaning-sized chunks:

- **āp se** — with you
- **mil kar** — having met
- **khushī huī** — happiness happened

That yields the memorable literal picture: “**Having met you, happiness happened.**” The phrase is one social move; later lessons can generalize *se*, *-kar*, and past agreement one at a time.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Khushī “happiness” comes from Persian **khosh/khush** “pleasant, happy.” **Mil** “meet” and **huī** “happened” belong to Urdu’s inherited Indo-Aryan grammar. The sentence therefore joins Urdu’s two major historical layers without becoming any less ordinary Urdu.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- **āp se | mil kar | khushī huī** in three beats
- the literal picture — “having met you, happiness happened”
- which word came through Persian — **khushī**

Before you move on

Say the response once as a whole. Which chunk means “happiness happened”? (**Khushī huī.**)

Source: *Basic Urdu: Greetings and Introductions*.

3.5 Practice — a complete Urdu name exchange

Recall the four moves without adding anything: greet, ask, answer, acknowledge.

The exchange

A: سلام! — *Salām!* B: سلام! — *Salām!* A: ہے؟ کیا نام کا آپ —
Āp kā nām kyā hai? B: ہے۔ سارا نام میرا — *Merā nām Sārā*
hai. A: آپ سے مل کر خوشی ہوئی۔ — *Āp se mil kar khushī huī.*
 B: شکریہ۔ — *Shukriyā.*

Every line is already known. **Āp** keeps the meeting respectful; **hai** stays at the end of both name sentences; ؟ ends the question at the line's left.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- both voices, using your own name
- the exchange again without romanization
- only the three name moves — question, answer, response

Before you move on

Run the meeting once from **salām** to **shukriyā**. If a line stalls, review only that micro-lesson.

Chapter 4

How Are You?

Modes: 🗣️ voice (6) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 6 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask how someone is with respectful āp, choose kaise or kaisī for the person I am addressing, and reply that I am fine, thank you.

The wellbeing exchange run both ways — āp kaise haiñ? and āp kaisī haiñ? — answered with the unchanging main̄ thīk hūñ, shukriyā.

4.1 کیسی / کیسے — “how” follows the addressee

Say **kyā** “what.” Urdu’s next question word begins with the same **k** family, but its ending changes with the person being addressed.

The two words

Urdu	read	use in the respectful question
کیسے	<i>kaise</i>	addressing a man
کیسی	<i>kaisī</i>	addressing a woman

Both begin ک *k* + ی *y* carrying the *ai* sound. At the left edge, کیسے ends in broad ے *e*, while کیسی ends in ی *y* long *ī*. Read the whole word before isolating the final shape.

Grammar Lens: one agreement contrast

English keeps *how* unchanged. Urdu makes this describing form agree with the person addressed: **kaise** for a man, **kaisī** for a woman. Learn only this pair today—not a table of adjective endings. Respectful **āp** itself remains the same for everyone.

Your turn

- *Say it*: addressing a man — **kaise**
- *Say it*: addressing a woman — **kaisī**
- *Point to*: broad final ے versus long-*ī* ی

Before you move on

Which form addresses a man? (**Kaise**.) A woman? (**Kaisī**.)
Source: *Basic Urdu: Formal Conversation*.

4.2 آپ کیسے آپ / ہیں؟ کیسی آپ — ask respectfully

Choose respectful **āp**. Then choose **kaise** for a man or **kaisī** for a woman. One final copula completes the question.

The exchange

to a man: آپ کیسے ہیں؟ — *āp kaise haiṅ?* to a woman: آپ کیسی ہیں؟ — *āp kaisī haiṅ?*

The order is **you** + **how** + **are?** Keep ہیں *haiṅ* final, just as ہے *hai* stayed final in the name question. Respectful **āp** takes this plural-shaped copula even when speaking to one person.

Grammar Lens: respect does not erase agreement

Both lines are respectful. The choice between **kaise** and **kaisī** tracks the person addressed, not greater or lesser politeness. If you do not know how a person wishes to be addressed, listen for their usage or ask rather than guess; the grammar lesson does not replace social judgment.

Your turn

- *Say it:* to a man — **āp kaise haiñ?**
- *Say it:* to a woman — **āp kaisī haiñ?**
- *Keep:* respectful **āp** and final **haiñ** in both

Before you move on

What stays the same in both lines? (**Āp ... haiñ.**) What changes? (**Kaise / kaisī.**)

Sources: *Basic Urdu: Formal Conversation and Personal Pronouns* with “To Be”.

4.3 میں ... ہوں — one frame for “I am ...”

Ask **āp kaise haiñ?** You know the respectful “you are” ending **haiñ**. Your answer needs the first-person pair “I ... am.”

You’ll want to know first — the frame

میں ... ہوں — *main ... hūñ* — I am ...

میں *main* means “I.” Final ں marks a nasal ending. ہوں *hūñ* means “am” and carries long *ū* with ھ, followed again by nasal ں. Leave a space for the state word that comes next.

Grammar Lens: the verb closes the frame

Urdu puts the copula at the end:

main + [state] + hūñ — I + [state] + am

Learn only this first-person frame. You do not need the full copula

chart to answer one wellbeing question. Notice the useful contrast: respectful **āp ... haiñ**, but first-person **maiñ ... hūñ**.

Your turn

- Say it: **maiñ** — I
- Say it: **hūñ** — am
- Frame: **maiñ ... hūñ**, leaving the middle open

Before you move on

Which word opens the answer? (**Maiñ.**) Which copula closes it? (**Hūñ.**)
 Source: *Basic Urdu*: Personal Pronouns with “To Be”.

4.4 ٹھیک — “fine,” “well,” and “correct”

Open and close the answer frame: **maiñ ... hūñ**. The middle now gets one high-frequency state word.

You’ll want to know first — the word

ٹھیک — *ṭhīk* — fine, well, correct

The first sound is retroflex and aspirated: curl the tongue slightly back for **ٹ** *ṭ*, then release a puff marked by **ھ**. A plain English *t* is a useful first approximation while the contrast settles. **ی** carries long *ī* before final **ک** *k*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Urdu **ٹھیک** and Hindi *ṭhīk* are the same everyday Hindustani word. Their grammar is closely shared; their scripts make different literary histories visible. This Urdu lesson leaves the Hindi side romanized: mixed-language practice may show both scripts only after each form has been learned in its own right.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **ṭhīk** — fine, well
- *Feel:* tongue slightly back, then a small puff
- *Connect:* Urdu ٹھیک ↔ Hindi *thīk*

Before you move on

Where will **ṭhīk** go in the frame **maiṅ ... hūṅ**? (In the middle.)
Source: *Basic Urdu: Greetings and Introductions*.

4.5 شکر یہ ہوں، ٹھیک میں — “I am fine, thank you”

Fill the frame **maiṅ ... hūṅ** with **ṭhīk**, then recall Chapter 1’s **shukriyā**.

The exchange

شکر یہ ہوں، ٹھیک میں *Main ṭhīk hūṅ, shukriyā. I am fine, thank you.*

No word is new. The step is assembling the words quickly enough to answer a real person.

Grammar Lens: keep the copula final

The core reply is:

I + fine + am → **maiṅ ṭhīk hūṅ**

English places “am” after “I”; Urdu closes the clause with **hūṅ**.

Shukriyā comes after the completed answer as the courtesy move you already own.

Your turn

- *Build:* **maiṅ + ṭhīk + hūṅ**

- *Add: shukriyā*
- *Say it:* the full reply without translating each word

Before you move on

Which word must close the core answer? (**Hūñ.**)
Source: *Basic Urdu: Formal Conversation.*

4.6 Practice — an Urdu wellbeing exchange

Choose the question ending for the person addressed, then retrieve the complete answer before looking below.

The exchange

A to a man: **ہیں؟ کیسے آپ! سلام** *Salām! Āp kaise haiñ?* A to a

woman: **ہیں؟ کیسی آپ! سلام** *Salām! Āp kaisī haiñ?* B: **ٹھیک میں**

شکریہ۔ ہوں، *Maiñ ṭhīk hūñ, shukriyā.*

The question keeps respectful **āp** and final **haiñ** while **kaise/kaisī** agrees with the addressee. The reply is unchanged for the speaker's gender: **ṭhīk** does not change, and first-person **hūñ** closes the line.

Grammar Lens: separate grammar from guessing

The two question forms are a grammatical contrast, not an instruction to infer someone's identity. In real interaction, follow the person's own language or ask. The stable beginner default is respect: **āp ... haiñ.**

Your turn

- *Say it:* the man-addressed exchange
- *Say it:* the woman-addressed exchange
- *Answer:* **maiñ ṭhīk hūñ, shukriyā** after either question

Before you move on

Run both question variants once. If the choice stalls, review only **kaise/kaisī**; if the answer order stalls, review only **maiñ ... hūñ**.

Chapter 5

Take Leave

Modes: ⇄ voice (3) 👁 eyes (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can open a short Urdu conversation, ask how the other person is, and close it with khudā hāfiz.

A four-line interaction with a beginning and an end: salām, the wellbeing check, then khudā hāfiz from both voices.

5.1 خد — the first half of an Urdu farewell

Run one known wellbeing exchange. Chapter 5 will add only the move that ends it.

You’ll want to know first — one word

خد — khudā — God

Read from right to left: خ kh + د d + ā long ā. The short u is learned with the word and is normally unwritten. Let **kh** come from farther back than English *h*, but keep the sound relaxed.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Urdu borrowed **khudā** from Persian **khodā**, whose older Middle Persian ancestor *xwadāy* meant “lord.” Learn the Urdu sound and script first; the Persian connection then explains why both tracks will share the phrase’s first historical layer.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **khudā** — God
- *Read it:* خدا from the right edge
- *Connect:* Urdu **khudā** ← Persian **khodā**

Before you move on

Which final letter carries long ā? (l.) Which short vowel must be remembered with the word? (u.)

Sources: *Basic Urdu: Greetings and Introductions*; Wiktionary: خدا.

5.2 حافظ — “guardian” or “protector”

Read خدا and say **khudā**. Keep it separate while one second word is added.

You’ll want to know first — one word

حافظ — *hāfiz* — guardian, protector

Read حافظ from right to left. ا carries long ā. Final ف is pronounced **z** in this Urdu word. The short *i* is heard in **hāfiz** but is normally not written as a separate letter.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Arabic **ḥāfiz** is an active participle from ḥ-f-z, “guard, preserve.” Urdu receives **hāfiz** through its Persian-Arabic literary layer. Keep “guardian” as the useful meaning; the three-consonant root is a memory hook.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **hāfiz** — guardian, protector
- *Read it:* حافظ
- *Connect:* Arabic ḥ-f-z — guard, preserve

Before you move on

What does **hāfiz** contribute to the farewell? (The idea of guarding or protecting.)

Source: American Heritage Dictionary: *hafiz*.

5.3 حافظ خدا — goodbye

Retrieve **khudā** and **hāfiz** separately: “God” + “guardian.”
Now use the two known pieces as one parting move.

The two words — put the known pieces together

حافظ خدا — *khudā hāfiz* — goodbye

Urdu keeps a visible space between the two words. Read خدا first, then حافظ, and preserve that space in the complete spelling حافظ خدا. Say the whole expression smoothly.

Grammar Lens — a whole social move

The protective sense is “God [be] guardian,” but everyday speakers use the formula simply as **goodbye**. No new verb or agreement ending is needed. It is a reliable polite close for the short interaction learned so far.

Script Bridge — shared history, local spacing

Urdu حافظ خدا and Persian خدا حافظ share the same historical pieces. Urdu conventionally keeps the visible space; Persian normally joins them. Mixed practice may compare the two only now that each local phrase is independently readable.

Your turn

- *Build:* **khudā** + **hāfiz**
- *Read it:* spaced Urdu حافظ خدا
- *Use:* say it when the interaction ends

Before you move on

Where is the local writing contrast? (Urdu shows a space; Persian joins its spelling.)

Source: *Basic Urdu: Greetings and Introductions*.

5.4 Practice — open, check, and close

Retrieve the known expression for the beginning and the new expression for the end. Keep the middle unchanged.

The exchange — the complete interaction

A: ہوں، ٹھیک میں؟ کیسے آپ! سلام! *Salām! Āp kaise hain?* B: شکر ہے۔
Maini ṭhīk hūn, shukriyā. A: حافظہ خدا۔ *Khudā hāfiz.* B:
 حافظہ خدا۔ *Khudā hāfiz.*

Every line is already learned. **Salām** opens; **khudā hāfiz** closes. The same farewell works for both speakers, so this practice adds no gender choice, pronoun, or copula form.

Your turn

- *Choose*: meeting begins → **salām**
- *Choose*: interaction ends → **khudā hāfiz**
- *Run through*: both voices once with script, once without romanization

Before you move on

Run the full exchange once. If the final line stalls, return only to the assembled-farewell lesson.

Chapter 6

Five Verbs at the Core

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name five everyday Urdu verbs by their shared -nā ending, take that ending off to reach the stem, and say what I do in the present with the participle agreeing for gender and the copula agreeing for person.

The fifth verb runs the whole machine at once: strip -nā from all five infinitives, hold the doubled nūn that keeps jānnā apart from jānā, and put the stem into main jāntā/jāntī hūn.

6.1 ہونا — “to be,” and the ending every Urdu verb wears

You can already close an Urdu sentence with ہوں *hūn* — “am.” That small word is a fragment of something larger. Here is the whole verb it was broken off.

You’ll want to know first — one word

ہونا — *honā* — to be

Read from the right edge: ہ *h*, then ں carrying *o*, then ن *n*, then ā long *ā*. Every one of those four shapes has already turned up in a word you have met. There is nothing new to decode here, which is rare, and worth enjoying.

Grammar Lens: the ending that names every verb

honā ends in **-نā**. So does every Urdu verb when you name it. English marks a verb's plain name by putting a word in front — *to be*, *to go*, *to come*. Urdu marks it by putting **-nā** on the end, and never uses a separate word for it. That ending is also a tool. Strip **-nā** off and what remains is the **stem**, the piece everything else in the verb is built on. **honā** minus **-nā** leaves **ho-**. Learn the ending once, and every new verb hands you its own stem for free.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

honā comes from Sanskrit *bhavati*, “becomes,” built on the root *bhū-*. The middle stage of Indo-Aryan softened that *bh-* to *h-*, so *bhavati* thinned to *hoi* and then to **honā**. The root is Indo-European: **b^huH-*, “grow, become.” English kept it in **be** and **been**, and — by way of “the place where one dwells” — in **build**, **booth**, and **bower**. Latin held it as *fuī* “I was” and *futūrus*, which English borrowed as **future**. Greek held it as *phúsis* “nature,” which English borrowed as **physics**.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **honā** — to be
- *Strip:* **honā** minus **-nā** leaves the stem **ho-**
- *Read it:* **نā** from the right edge
- *Connect:* **honā** ← Sanskrit *bhavati* → English **be**

Before you move on

Which ending names an Urdu verb? (**-nā**.) What is left of *honā* once you take that ending off? (**Ho-**.) Which English verb grew from the same ancient root? (**Be**.)

Sources: *Basic Urdu*: Personal Pronouns with “To Be”; Wiktionary: **نā**.

6.2 جانا — “to go,” and two agreements in one sentence

Take the ending off **honā** and say the stem aloud. The next verb gives that same ending a second workout.

You’ll want to know first — one word

جانا — *jānā* — to go

From the right edge: ج *j*, then / long *ā*, then ن *n*, then / long *ā*. The ج is the one from جي *jī*. Strip the **-nā** and the stem is **jā-**.

Grammar Lens: the present tense agrees twice

“I go” in Urdu is two words after the pronoun, not one:

ہوں جاتا میں — *main jātā hūn* — I go (man speaking) میں
ہوں جاتی — *main jātī hūn* — I go (woman speaking)

The first word is the stem **jā-** plus **-tā**. It says *going*, and it agrees with the **gender and number** of the person doing it: **-tā** for one man, **-tī** for one woman, **-te** for more than one man or for a respectful singular. The second word is **hūn**, which you already own, and it agrees with **person** — who is speaking.

Two agreements, split across two words, in one short clause. English makes one agreement at most, and usually none. Say both Urdu lines and let the difference sit in the ear rather than on paper.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

jānā continues Sanskrit *yāti*, “goes,” from the root *yā-*, “travel.” The change from *y-* to *j-* is not a quirk of this word: initial *y-* regularly hardened to *j-* on the road from Sanskrit into the middle stage of Indo-Aryan that Urdu descends from. Meet the law once and it decodes other words later.

English gives nothing here. The *yā-* root travelled north and west into Lithuanian and Slavic rather than into Germanic, so this is a word where Sanskrit is the whole hook and English cannot help.

Your turn

- Say it: **jānā** — to go
- Strip: **jānā** minus **-nā** leaves **jā-**
- Say it: **maiṅ jātā hūṅ**, then **maiṅ jātī hūṅ**
- Choose: the ending that fits you — **-tā** or **-tī**

Before you move on

Which word in *maiṅ jātā hūṅ* carries gender? (**Jātā** — the one built on the stem.) Which one carries person? (**Hūṅ**.) And which Sanskrit verb stands behind *jānā*? (*Yā-*, “travel.”)
Source: Wiktionary: **جاء**.

6.3 آ — “to come,” which is “go” pointed back at you

Say **jānā**, then its stem **jā-**. The opposite direction is the same verb wearing a prefix.

You’ll want to know first — one word

آ — *ānā* — to come

From the right edge: **آ**, then **ن** *n*, then **ا** long *ā*. That first shape is *alif madd* — alif wearing a small wave — and it is how Urdu writes a long *ā* at the start of a word. It opens **آپ** *āp* too. Strip the **-nā** and the stem is **ā-**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ānā continues Sanskrit *āyāti*, and that word is two pieces: *ā-*, “toward,” plus *yā-*, “go.” So the Urdu verb for *coming* is, underneath, the verb for *going* aimed back at the speaker. “Go toward me” is “come.”

You already have the second piece: *yā-* is the same root that hardened into the **j-** of **jānā**. One Sanskrit verb, two Urdu words, and the difference between them is a direction marker.

English does the identical trick with a Latin verb: *venīre* “to come”

plus a prefix gives **advent**, **convene**, **intervene**, **prevent**, and **revenue**. Urdu welds its prefix on the front and lets the seam disappear; English keeps the seam visible.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **ānā** — to come
- *Pair:* **jānā** away, **ānā** toward
- *Split:* **ā-** “toward” + **yā-** “go”
- *Read it:* **آنا**, starting from *alif madd*

Before you move on

Which two pieces are hiding inside **ānā**? (**Ā-** “toward” and **yā-** “go.”) Which Urdu verb shares the second piece? (**Jānā**.) And what does the stem become once **-nā** comes off? (**Ā-**.)

Source: Wiktionary: **آنا**.

6.4 بولنا — “to speak,” and the two layers of Urdu

Retrieve the opening without looking: **shukriyā** — **jī hā** — **nahī**. Air-trace the five shapes of the thank-you word once. Then return to the three verbs whose stems you pulled from the same ending. Here is a fourth, with one new letter.

You’ll want to know first — one word

بولنا — **bolnā** — to speak

From the right edge: **ب** *b*, then **و** carrying *o*, then **ل** *l*, then **ن** *n*, then **ا** long *ā*. Strip the **-nā** and the stem is **bol-**.

ب is new, and it is worth one careful second. Its body is a single low scoop with **one dot below**. You have already read **پ** *p* in **پآ** *āp*, and **پ** is that identical scoop with **three dots below**. Same skeleton, different dot count, different consonant. Urdu builds much of its alphabet this way, so counting dots is a real reading skill and not a fussy detail.

Grammar Lens: put it in the frame

The stem takes the same two-agreement frame as before:

ہوں بولتا میں — *maiñ boltā hūñ* — **I speak** (man speaking)

ہوں بولتی میں — *maiñ boltī hūñ* — **I speak** (woman speaking)

Nothing new is being learned there. That is the point of a stem: the machine is already built, and each verb just walks into it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

bolnā goes back to Prakrit *bolai*, “speaks” — and then the trail stops. A link onward to Sanskrit *brūte* “speaks” has been proposed, but it is not settled, so treat it as a maybe rather than a fact.

That plainness is the lesson. Urdu’s everyday verbs are inherited Indo-Aryan and often short-rooted like this, while its formal and literary vocabulary was borrowed from Persian and Arabic and tends to be long, elegant, and easy to trace. Beside homely **bolnā** sits

Persian-derived گفتگو *guftagū*, “conversation,” from Persian *guftan*, “to speak.” Both are fully Urdu. One is the floor of the house; the other is the ornament on it — and the flowing *nasta‘līq* hand Urdu is traditionally written in belongs to that same Persian inheritance.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **bolnā** — to speak
- *Count:* ۛ one dot below, ۛ three dots below
- *Say it:* **maiñ boltā hūñ**, then **maiñ boltī hūñ**
- *Sort:* **bolnā** inherited, **guftagū** borrowed

Before you move on

How many dots does ۛ carry, and where? (One, below.) How far back can *bolnā* be traced with confidence? (To Prakrit *bolai*, and no further.) Which layer of Urdu does *guftagū* belong to? (The Persian one.)

Sources: *Zero Zabar*: The Urdu alphabet; Wiktionary: جاننا.

6.5 جاننا — “to know,” a word English has been carrying all along

Run the four verbs you have — *honā*, *jānā*, *ānā*, *bolnā* — and pull the stem off each one. The fifth is the closest of them to English.

You’ll want to know first — one word

جاننا — *jānnā* — to know

From the right edge: ج *j*, / long *ā*, then ن, then ن a second time, then / long *ā*. Two separate nūns, written out one after the other, and both are pronounced: hold the *n* long, *jān-nā*, the way English does across the seam of *thin · ness*. Strip the final **-nā** and the stem is **jān-**.

That doubling is what keeps **jānnā** “to know” apart from **jānā** “to go.” One letter, and the whole meaning turns.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

jānnā continues Sanskrit *jānāti*, from the root *jñā-*, “know.” That root is Indo-European **ǵneh₃-*, and English is stuffed with it.

Straight down the Germanic line: **know**, **knowledge**, **can** (once “to know how”), **cunning**, **ken**, and **uncouth** — literally “un-known.”

Borrowed from Latin (*g*)*nōscere*: **notice**, **note**, **notion**, **cognition**, **recognize**, **acquaint**, and **ignore**, which is “not to know.” Borrowed from Greek *gnōsis*: **diagnosis**, **prognosis**, and **agnostic**.

So the Urdu verb is not a stranger. It is a first cousin of the plainest word English has for the same idea, and every one of those borrowings is another place to hang it.

Your turn

- Say it: **jānnā** — to know, holding the long *n*
- Contrast: **jānā** to go, **jānnā** to know
- Say it: **main jāntā hūn**, then **main jāntī hūn**

- *Run through:* all five — *honā, jānā, ānā, bolnā, jānnā* — stripping each stem
- *Connect:* **jānnā** ← *jñā-* → English **know**, **notice**, **diagnosis**

Before you move on

What single written difference separates *jānā* from *jānnā*? (A second ج, held long in speech.) Which two words in *main jāntī hūnī* agree, and with what? (**Jāntī** with gender, **hūnī** with person.) And which English verb is the same word as *jānnā*? (**Know**.)
Source: Wiktionary: جَانَا.

Chapter 7

Four Verbs of the Mind

Modes: 👁 eyes (4) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say that I think, understand, read and write in Urdu, take the -nā off each verb to reach its stem, and read the two-eyed he that turns a plain consonant into an aspirated one.

The fourth verb arrives with no new letters at all: read لکھنا straight off, then run all four stems through main ...tā/tī hūn and sort the chapter's inherited verbs from the borrowed words for pen, book and script.

7.1 سوچنا — “to think,” and it used to mean “to grieve”

Say **jānnā** — the one with the doubled *n*, the one that turned out to be English **know**. Knowing is where the mind arrives. Here is the verb for the work it does on the way.

You'll want to know first — one word

سوچنا — *sochnā* — to think

Strip the -nā and the stem is **soch-**. That stem is also a noun: سوچ *soch*, “a thought” — and, just as ordinarily, “a worry.” Both meanings matter; the history explains them.

The letters in this word

From the right edge: س *s*, then و carrying *o*, then چ *ch*, then ن *n*, then ا long *ā*.

چ is new, and you own the trick already. It is the body of ج *j* — from جی *jī* and جانا *jānā* — with **three dots below** instead of one. Second time this has happened: ب *b* has one dot below the low scoop, پ *p* has three. Counting dots stays a reading skill.

Grammar Lens: nothing new to run it

ہوں سوچتا میں — *maiñ sochtā hūñ* — **I think** (man speaking)
ہوں سوچتی میں — *maiñ sochtī hūñ* — **I think** (woman speaking)

The participle takes gender, ہوں takes person. The machine is built; every new verb walks into it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sochnā comes through Prakrit *soccadi* from Sanskrit *śocati* — “**burns; grieves; mourns**” — on the root *śuc-*. The sense cooled by stages: *burn* → *be consumed by something* → *brood on it* → plain *think*. Urdu’s everyday word for thinking is an old word for sorrow that went quiet, which is why **soch** is still a thought *and* a worry. State the limit plainly: *śuc-* has **no secure English cousin**.

Inventing one would be worse than admitting it.

What is worth noticing sits inside Urdu. Beside inherited **soch**, Urdu

keeps Arabic فکر *fikr*, “thought, reflection,” on the root *f-k-r* — and *fikr* also means **worry**: *koī fikr nahīñ*, “no worries.” Two words, two unrelated languages, opposite sides of Urdu’s vocabulary, each sliding from thinking to fretting on its own.

Your turn

- Say it: **sochnā** — to think; then the stem **soch-**
- Count: چ one dot below, ج three dots below
- Say it: **maiñ sochtā hūñ**, then **maiñ sochtī hūñ**

- *Run through:* **bolnā**, **jānnā**, **sochnā** — speak, know, think
- *Say it:* both meanings of the noun **soch** — a thought, and a worry

Before you move on

How many dots does ج carry, and where? (Three, below.) What did *śocati* mean before it meant “think”? (**To burn, to grieve.**) Is there an English cousin of *śuc*-? (**No.**)

Sources: Wiktionary: سوچنا; *Zero Zabar*: The Urdu alphabet.

7.2 سمجھنا — “to understand,” which is a way of waking up

You can think — *sochnā*, three dots under the ج. You can know — *jānnā*. Between brooding and knowing sits the moment a thing clicks, and Urdu has a verb for exactly that.

You’ll want to know first — one word

سمجھنا — *samaḡhnā* — to understand

Strip the **-nā** and the stem is **samaḡh-**. The stem is a noun too: *samaḡh*, “understanding, sense.”

The letters in this word

From the right edge: س *s*, م *m*, ج *j*, then ه, then ن *n*, then | long *ā*.

ه is *do-chashmī he*, “two-eyed he,” named for its two loops. It is not a consonant you pronounce. Its whole job is to grab the letter before it and add a puff of breath: ج *j* plus ه gives جھ *jh*.

You have used it once already. ٹھیک *ṭhīk* is ٹ plus this same ه — retroflex *ṭ*, then the breath. One letter, one job.

Keep it apart from ہ, *gol he*, “round he,” which is a real *h* and which you write in ہوں *hūn* and ہونا *honā*. Round ہ speaks; two-eyed ه only breathes on its right-hand neighbour.

Grammar Lens: into the frame

ہوں سمجھتا میں — *main samajhtā hūn* — I understand

(man speaking) ہوں سمجھتی میں — *main samajhtī hūn* — I understand (woman speaking)

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

samajhnā comes through Prakrit *sambujjhadī* from Sanskrit *sambudhyate*: **sam-**, “fully, together,” plus **budh-**, “to wake; to become aware.” To understand something is to come awake to it. That root has a famous derivative. **Buddha** is *buddha*, “the woken one” — the same *budh-*, as are *bodhi*, the awakening, and *buddhi*, “intellect.” English borrowed all three without noticing they were relatives of anything.

One stage back the root is Indo-European **b^hewd^h-*, “be awake, be aware.” Its English descendants are quieter: **bode** and **forebode**, about being warned, and **forbid** — Old English *bēodan*, “to announce, to command,” a word for making someone aware of your will. So Urdu’s plainest way of saying *I get it* and the Buddha’s title are one word.

Your turn

- Say it: **samajhnā** — to understand; then the stem **samajh-**
- Say it: **ṭhīk**, then **samajhnā** — hear the same **ḥ** breath in both
- Contrast: **ḥ** speaks in *hūn*; **h** only aspirates in *samajh-*
- Say it: **main sochtā hūn**, then **main samajhtā hūn** — I think, I understand
- Connect: **samajhnā** ← *budh-* → **Buddha**, “the woken one”

Before you move on

What does **ḥ** do, and does it sound by itself? (It aspirates the letter before it; **no**.) What did *budh-* mean, and which famous title is built on it? (**To wake; Buddha**.)

Sources: Wiktionary: سمجھنا ; Zero Zabar: The Urdu alphabet.

7.3 پڑھنا — “to read,” and “to study,” and “to recite”

Say **samajhnā**, strip its **-nā**, and hear the breath the two-eyed **ھ** puts into the stem. This verb uses that letter and one more.

You’ll want to know first — one word

پڑھنا — *paṛhnā* — **to read**

It is also the ordinary word for “**to study**”: the noun پڑھائی *paṛhāī* is “studies, schooling.” Urdu does not keep reading and studying in separate boxes. Strip the **-nā** and the stem is **paṛh-**.

The letters in this word

From the right edge: پ *p*, then ر *r*, then ھ *h*, then ن *n*, then | long *ā*.

Two are yours: پ, the low scoop with **three dots below**, from آپ *āp*; and ھ, the two-eyed *he* from سمجھنا — ر plus ھ gives *rh*. ر is new, and built from two things you have met. Its body is ر *r*, from شکریہ *shukriyā*. On top sits the very mark that rides on ٹ in ٹھیک *ṭhīk*: Urdu’s retroflex sign, meaning *curl the tongue back*. ٹ is a curled *t*; ر is a curled *r*, flicked rather than rolled.

Grammar Lens: into the frame

ہوں پڑھتا میں — *main paṛhtā hūn* — **I read** (man speaking)
ہوں پڑھتی میں — *main paṛhtī hūn* — **I read** (woman speaking)

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

paṛhnā comes from Prakrit *paḍhai*, from Sanskrit **paṭh-**, “**to recite; to read aloud**.” Its *ṭh* softened into the flapped *rh* you have just

learned, and the meaning widened from reciting to reading to studying. Be honest about the far end: **paṭh-** has **no secure Indo-European ancestry**. There is no English cousin, and the trail stops inside India. The near end is better. The oldest sense — *speaking a text you hold in memory* — is everyday, not a fossil. To perform the Muslim ritual prayer is **پڑھنا نماز** *namāz paṛhnā*, literally “to **read** the prayer,” and nobody performing it holds a book. You already met the word for someone who does that with the whole Quran: a **حافظ** *hāfiz*, on the Arabic root *ḥ-f-ẓ*, “to guard, to preserve.” Guarding a text and reciting it are two halves of one practice — one word borrowed, one inherited.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **paṛhnā** — to read, and to study; then the stem **paṛh-**
- *Count:* **پ** three dots below, and name the word it opens
- *Trace it:* the retroflex mark on **ٹ**, then the same mark on **ڑ**
- *Say it:* **maiṅ paṛhtā hūñ**, then **maiṅ samajhtā hūñ** — I read, I understand

Before you move on

Name the two everyday meanings of *paṛhnā*. (**To read; to study.**)
 What does the mark on **ڑ** tell you to do, and which other letter carries it? (**Curl the tongue back; ٹ.**) Does *paṭh-* have an English cousin? (**No.**)
 Sources: Wiktionary: **پڑھنا**; *Zero Zabar*: The Urdu alphabet.

7.4 لکھنا — “to write,” with nothing new left to decode

Three verbs so far: *sochnā*, *samajhnā*, *paṛhnā*. Strip the ending off each and say the three stems. The fourth completes the set, and every letter in it is one you already own.

You'll want to know first — one word

لکھنا — *likhnā* — to write

Strip the **-nā** and the stem is **likh-**.

The letters in this word

From the right edge: ل *l*, from سلام *salām*; ک *k*, from کیا *kyā*; then ه, the two-eyed *he*, aspirating the ک to give کھ *kh*; then ن *n* and ا long *ā*.
Not one new shape — a whole verb you can read straight off.

Grammar Lens: all four in the frame

ہوں لکھتا میں — *main likhtā hūn* — **I write** (man speaking)

ہوں لکھتی میں — *main likhtī hūn* — **I write** (woman speaking)

Run the chapter through that frame without changing anything but the stem: *main sochtā hūn*, *main samajhtā hūn*, *main parhtā hūn*, *main likhtā hūn*. One machine, four verbs, and ہوں میں holding the ends of every sentence.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

likhnā is Sanskrit *likhati*, “**scratches, scrapes**.” Writing was cutting a mark into a surface. Three other families reached for that picture out of three unrelated roots: Latin *scribere* “to incise,” behind **scribe** and **script**; Greek *gráphein* “to scratch,” behind **graph**; Old English *writan* “to score, to cut,” which is **write**. Four families, each deciding that writing is scratching.

Now the part only Urdu can show you. All four verbs of this chapter are inherited Indo-Aryan, the plain floor of the language — but the

things writing needs are borrowed to a word: قلم *qalam*, the pen,

Arabic from Greek *kálamos*, “a reed”; کتاب *kitāb*, the book, from the

Arabic root *k-t-b*, “to write”; and نستعلیق *nasta‘līq*, the Persian name of the flowing hand Urdu is set in. The deed is inherited; the equipment came by ship.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **likhnā** — to write; then the stem **likh-**
- *Run through:* all four — *sochnā*, *samajhnā*, *parhnā*, *likhnā* — stripping each stem
- *Say it:* the four in the frame — *main sochtā hūn ... main likhtā hūn*
- *Name:* which letter is چ, which is ٹ, and what ہ does to a neighbour
- *Trace it:* *soch-* from grieving, *samajh-* from waking, *parh-* from reciting
- *Sort:* **likhnā** inherited; **qalam** and **kitāb** borrowed

Before you move on

Name the four verbs of this chapter and their four stems. What did *likhati* mean before it meant “write”? (**Scratches.**) Which layer of Urdu does *qalam* belong to? (**The borrowed one.**)

Sources: Wiktionary: لکھنا; Wiktionary: قلم.

Chapter 8

Four Verbs Between People

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) 👁 eyes (3) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can take, ask and help in Urdu, build a verb by bolting a borrowed noun onto karnā, and say what I like in the sentence where the thing liked is the subject and I am only the person it happens to.

mujhe paṛhnā pasand hai — the first Urdu sentence the learner cannot open with mainī. It closes over the chapter's own four verbs by dropping each -nā infinitive into the liked-thing slot, and reuses madad karnā's join in pasand karnā.

8.1 لینا — “to take,” and the letter that will not sit still

Last chapter's four verbs were about the mind. Say **likhnā**, and name which layer of Urdu *qalam* came from. Now the hands take over: four verbs about what happens between people.

You'll want to know first — one word

لینا — *lenā* — **to take**

Strip the **-nā** and the stem is **le-**. That is the whole stem: one syllable, no consonant after the vowel. It is the shortest verb you have met, and the etymology says why.

The letters in this word

From the right edge: ل *l*, then ی *y*, then ن *n*, then ا long *ā*.

ی here carries a long *e* — *le-*, rhyming with English *lay*. That is its **third** job: it supplied a consonantal *y* in کیا *kyā* and stood for long *ī* in جی *jī*.

A fourth relative is yours too: broad final ے, which ends کیسے *kaise* and is not the shape that ends کیسی *kaisī*. One family of *ye* shapes covering *y*, *ī* and *e*, with the learned word telling you which — the abjad recording enough, not everything.

Grammar Lens: a two-letter stem in the same frame

ہوں لیتا میں — *maĩn letā hūñ* — **I take** (man speaking) میں
ہوں لیتی — *maĩn letī hūñ* — **I take** (woman speaking)

No stem is too small for the machine. **le-** plus **-tā/-tī** plus **hūñ**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

lenā goes back to Sanskrit **labh-**, “**to gain, to obtain**.” Prakrit softened it to *lahai*, then the *-h-* went too and the vowels fused into a single *le*. A three-consonant root worn down to one syllable — the erosion that makes a language’s commonest words its shortest. Prakrit then did something tidy: it levelled *le-* “take” against *de-* “give” so the pair matched. That is why لینا *lenā* and دینا *denā* still rhyme. They are not related; they were made to sound like partners. On the standard comparison, *labh-* matches Greek *lambánein*, “to take, to seize” — which English borrowed repeatedly without noticing. **Syllable** is *syn-* plus *lambánein*, “letters **taken together**”; **epilepsy** is “a seizing upon”; a **lemma** is something taken as given, which is why an argument with two of them is a **dilemma**.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **lenā** — to take; then the stem, which is just **le-**
- *Name:* ی three ways — *y* in *kyā*, *ī* in *jī*, *e* in *lenā*

- *Say it:* **maiṅ letā hūṅ**, then **maiṅ letī hūṅ**
- *Say it:* **maiṅ likhtā hūṅ**, then **maiṅ letā hūṅ** — I write, I take
- *Connect:* **lenā** ← *labh-* → Greek *lambánein* → English **syllable**

Before you move on

What sound does **ل** carry in *lenā*, and name one other value it takes elsewhere. (**Long e**; *y* in *kyā* or *ī* in *jī*.) What did *labh-* mean? (**To gain, to obtain.**) Why do *lenā* and *denā* rhyme? (**Prakrit levelled the pair.**)

Sources: Wiktionary: لینا; *Zero Zabar*: The Urdu alphabet.

8.2 پوچھنا — “to ask,” a word Urdu inherited and borrowed at the same time

Say **lenā** and name the sound **ل** carries in it. You also hold کیا *kyā*, “what,” and two whole questions built with it. Here is the verb for the act itself.

You’ll want to know first — one word

پوچھنا — *pūchhnā* — to ask

Strip the **-nā** and the stem is **pūchh-**. It covers both asking a question and asking after someone.

The letters in this word

From the right edge: پ *p*, then و carrying long *ū*, then چ *ch*, then ه, then ن *n*, then | long *ā*.

Every shape is already earned, and two are the dot-counting pair: پ has three dots **below** a low scoop, چ three below the taller *jīm* body. Then ه aspirates the چ into چھ *chh* — its job in *samajhnā* and *parhnā* too.

A written question still ends in the mirrored ؟, closing ہے؟ کیا نام کا آپ at the left-hand end of the line.

Grammar Lens: into the frame

ہوں پوچھتا میں — *maiṇ pūchhtā hūṇ* — I ask (man speaking)
ہوں پوچھتی میں — *maiṇ pūchhtī hūṇ* — I ask (woman speaking)

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

pūchhnā is Sanskrit **pr̥chati**, “asks,” on the Indo-European root **prek-*, “to ask.” Latin took it as *precārī*, “to beg, to pray” — hence English **pray**, **prayer**, and **precarious**, a thing held only as long as someone is willing to be asked. German still asks with it: *fragen*. English’s own inherited cousin, Old English *frīgnan*, died out, so English prays with the related word and asks with an unrelated one. Here is the part that is Urdu’s alone. Persian asks with پرسیدن *porsīdan*, and *porsīdan* is **the same root**, carried west into Iran rather than east into India. Urdu borrowed it back: پرسش *pursish* is “inquiry, asking after someone’s health,” and حال پرسان *pursān-e-ḥāl* is “one who asks how you are.”

So **pūchhnā** came down the inherited road, *pursish* came in sideways off a Persian ship, and they are cousins. Urdu is the room where the two roads meet, and the wellbeing question آپ کیسے ہیں؟ *āp kaisē hīṇ?* is what either of them names.

Your turn

- Say it: **pūchhnā** — to ask; then the stem **pūchh-**
- Count: three dots below پ, three below چ, then ھ for the breath
- Say it: **maiṇ pūchhtā hūṇ**, then **maiṇ pūchhtī hūṇ**
- Say it: **kyā**, then **āp kaise haiṇ** — a word and a question about asking
- Connect: **pūchhnā** and Persian **pursish** ← one root → English **pray**

Before you move on

Which English word for praying shares a root with *pūchhnā*, and are Persian *porṣīdan* and Urdu *pūchhnā* related? (**Pray; the same root, by two roads.**)

Sources: Wiktionary: پوچھنا; Wiktionary: پرسیدن; Rekhta Dictionary: pursish.

8.3 کرنا مدو — “to help,” and the join that built half of Urdu

Say *pūchhnā* and name the English word for praying that shares its root. Every verb so far was one word ending in **-nā**. This one is two, and only the second half moves.

You’ll want to know first — two words

کرنا مدو — *madad karnā* — **to help**

مدو *madad* is a **noun**: “help, aid.” Alone it does nothing. کرنا *karnā* is the verb “to do,” already readable: ک from *kyā*, ڑ from *shukriyā*, then نا. Bolt them together: “**to do help**.”

Grammar Lens: only the second half conjugates

ہوں کرتا مدو میں — *main madad kartā hūn* — **I help** (man speaking)
ہوں کرتی مدو میں — *main madad kartī hūn* — **I help** (woman speaking)

Madad never changes. It is not a verb and never becomes one; *karnā* carries every ending. This is the **conjunct verb**, the most productive verb-making device Urdu owns: name a noun, add *karnā*, and you have a verb.

You have met *karnā*’s stem before without being told. کر مل سے آپ

ہوئی خوشی — *āp se mil kar khushī huī* — holds کر *kar* in the middle doing a different job: “**having** met.” One little word, two pieces of machinery.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

مد is Arabic, on the three-consonant root م-د-د (*m-d-d*), whose verb *madda* means “**to stretch out, to extend.**” Help, in Arabic, is something **extended** toward you — the picture English reaches for when it *extends* a hand, though English inherited nothing from *m-d-d* and its own **help** is unrelated Germanic. Better said plainly than dressed up as a cousin.

The root pattern is not new. حافظ *hāfiz* sits on ظ-ف-ح, “to guard, to preserve.” Three consonants carrying a meaning, vowels poured in around them: that is how Arabic builds words, and now you have two. *Madad* travelled the same road as خدا *khudā* — into Persian first, then into Urdu.

Here is why the join matters more than the word. A borrowed noun **cannot be conjugated**. With *karnā* it never has to: the loan stays a frozen noun and native grammar does the work. That is how Urdu took in centuries of Persian and Arabic vocabulary without changing its verb system by one letter.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- **madad karnā** — to help; and which half is the noun
- **maiñ madad kartā hūñ**, then **maiñ madad kartī hūñ**
- two Arabic roots — *ḥ-f-ẓ* to guard, *m-d-d* to extend
- **maiñ pūchhtā hūñ**, then **maiñ madad kartā hūñ** — I ask, I help

Before you move on

Which half of *madad karnā* takes the endings, and what does *m-d-d* mean underneath? (کرنا; **to stretch out, to extend.**) Why does

this join let Urdu borrow so freely? (The loan stays a noun; native *karnā* carries the grammar.)
 Sources: Wiktionary: کرن; Wiktionary: كرن (Arabic).

8.4 پسند — Urdu does not like things; things please Urdu

Say **maiñ madad kartā hūñ** and name which half takes the endings. Every sentence so far opened with **میں** *maiñ*, “I.” This one takes that away.

You’ll want to know first — **مجھے**, the shape of “to me”

مجھے — *mujhe* — to me

Mujhe is what **میں** *maiñ* becomes when the sentence refuses to let you be its subject. It is not “I.”

The letters in this word

From the right edge: **م** *m*, **ج** *j*, **ه** aspirating it to *jh*, then broad final **ے**

for *e* — the shape that ends **کیسے** *kaise*. All four already yours.

Grammar Lens: the thing you like is the subject

پسند پڑھنا مجھے ہے۔ — *mujhe paṛhnā pasand hai.* — I like reading.

Taken apart: **mujhe** + **paṛhnā** (“reading”) + **pasand** (“pleasing”) + **hai**. Literally: “To me, reading is pleasing.”

پڑھنا is the **subject**, which is what **ہے** agrees with. No Urdu sentence puts *I* in front of *like*. And any **-nā** infinitive drops into that slot, because an Urdu infinitive doubles as a noun — so every verb of the last three chapters is likeable.

پسند لکھنا مجھے ہے۔ — *mujhe likhnā pasand hai.* — I like

writing.

Urdu keeps company with unrelated languages: Spanish *me gusta el libro*, “to me the book pleases”; Italian *mi piace*; Tamil *enakku pidikkum*, “it catches me”; Bengali *āmār bhālo lāge*, “good sticks to me.” Three families borrowing nothing from each other, each deciding liking happens to you.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

پسند is not a verb. It is **Persian**, from پسندیدن *pasandīdan*, “to approve, to find pleasing” — *pati-*, “towards,” plus *sand*, “to look good.” It arrived as a noun and adjective, and a non-verb cannot carry the liker, so the grammar put that person elsewhere: **mujhe**.

Where *sand* goes next is genuinely **disputed**. One proposal ties it to the root behind Latin *candēre*, “to glow” — English **candid**, **incendiary** — and Sanskrit *candra*, “moon,” Urdu’s چاند *chānd*. Lovely, but unsettled.

It came by the Persian road that gave you خوشی *khushī*, and sits beside Arabic مدد *madad*. *Lenā* and *pūchhnā* are inherited; *madad* and *pasand* are borrowed. Urdu’s hands stayed home; its social words travelled.

کرنا پسند *pasand karnā*, “to do liking,” reuses *madad karnā*’s join; پسند آنا *pasand ānā* uses آنا *ānā*, “to come” — liking that *comes*.

Your turn

- Say it: **mujhe paṛhnā pasand hai**, then its literal sense
- Swap: hold **mujhe ... pasand hai**, change the middle — *likhnā* · *sochnā* · *pūchhnā*
- Say it: the chapter — *maiṁ letā hūṁ*, *maiṁ pūchhtā hūṁ*, *maiṁ madad kartā hūṁ*, *mujhe paṛhnā pasand hai*
- Sort: *lenā*, *pūchhnā* inherited; *madad*, *pasand* borrowed

Before you move on

In *mujhe paṛhnā pasand hai*, what is the subject, and what part of speech is *pasand*? (پڑھنا; a **noun and adjective** from **Persian**.)

Sources: Wiktionary: پسند; Wiktionary: پسندیدن.

Chapter 9

People You’d Introduce

Modes: ⇄ voice (3) 👁 eyes (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name my brother, sister, friend and family in Urdu, and choose *merā* or *merī* correctly for each noun’s grammatical gender.

Say merā bhāī, merī bahan, merā dost and merā khāndān with merā/merī chosen correctly for each noun, and sort the four into inherited bhāī/bahan against Persian dost/khāndān — the same native-versus-borrowed split Chapter 8’s verbs drew.

9.1 بھائی — “brother,” and the first real English cousin among these nouns

Say **mujhe paṛhnā pasand hai**. That closed the verb chapters. This chapter opens a new kind of word: nouns for the people you would actually introduce.

You’ll want to know first — one word

بھائی — *bhāī* — brother

بھائی-میرا — *merā bhāī*. — “[He’s] my brother.”

Urdu, like English, can drop the subject when it is obvious from context — pointing at someone while you say this is enough.

The letters in this word

From the right edge: ب *b*, then ه aspirating it to *bh*, then ا long *ā*, then ي *y*, then ي *ī*.

ي is new: **ye with hamza above**. It is a fourth shape in the *ye* family,

alongside consonantal *y* in کیا, long *ī* in جی, and broad final *e* in کیسے. Its job is narrower than any of those: it marks a glide between two vowels that would otherwise collide — here, between *ā* and *ī*. ه is new too, extending the two-eyed *he* you already know from جھ, ٹھ, ٹھ and چھ to a fifth base letter, ب.

Grammar Lens: a noun with a gender

بھائی is grammatically **masculine** — the same class as نام in merā nām. That is why merā needs no change here. Not every noun agrees this easily; the next lesson breaks the pattern.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

bhāī comes from Sanskrit *bhrātṛ*, “brother,” from Proto-Indo-Iranian *b^hrāHtā, from Proto-Indo-European *b^hréh₂tēr. English **brother** comes from the very same root. Unlike پسند’s disputed link to *candēre* two lessons ago, this one is settled: Sanskrit and English are both Indo-European, so *bhāī* and *brother* are real relatives, not two languages landing on the same idea by accident.

Your turn

- Say it: **bhāī** — brother; then **merā bhāī**
- Name: the fourth *ye* shape — hamza above, between two vowels
- Connect: **bhāī** ← *bhrātṛ* → English **brother**, real cousins
- Say it: **mujhe paṛhnā pasand hai** once more, then **merā bhāī**

Before you move on

What does بھائی mean, and is بھائی masculine or feminine?
(**Brother; masculine.**) Which English word is its real cousin, not

just a resemblance? (**Brother.**) Name the four jobs of the *ye* family now. (**Consonantal *y*, long *ī*, final *e*, and hamza-glide.**)

Sources: Wiktionary: بھائی.

9.2 بہن — “sister,” and the word that makes میرا move

Say **merā bhāī** — my brother, a real cousin of the English word. Here is the other half of the pair, and it changes something you have used unchanged since Chapter 2.

You’ll want to know first — one word

بہن — *bahan* — sister

میری - بہن — *merī bahan*. — “[She’s] my sister.”

Not میرا بہن. Read on for why.

Grammar Lens: میرا bends to the noun, not to you

بہن is grammatically **feminine**. Urdu’s word for “my” carries that agreement: میرا *merā* before a masculine noun, میری *merī* before a feminine one — regardless of whether the speaker is a man or a woman. It is the noun’s gender that decides, never the speaker’s.

میرا - میری بھائی، میرا — *merā bhāī, merī bahan*. — my brother, my sister.

نام in Chapter 2’s **merā nām** is masculine, which is why that phrase never had to teach you this rule — one gender, hidden in plain sight, until a feminine noun finally showed up.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

bahan continues Sanskrit *bhaginī*, traditionally connected to **bhāj-**, “to share, to portion out” — a sister pictured as a co-heir, sharing the family’s portion. Specialists flag a real problem with the sound history,

though: the aspiration in *bhaginī* does not shift the way this derivation needs it to. Hold this one loosely, the way پسند's *candēre* link was held loosely — a plausible story, not a settled one like *bhāī*'s.

Your turn

- Say it: **bahan** — sister; then **merī bahan**
- Contrast: **merā bhāī** — **merī bahan**
- Say it: why **merā** changed — the noun's gender, not the speaker's
- Say it: **bahan** ← *bhaginī* ← *bhaj-*, “to share” — held loosely

Before you move on

Why is it **میری** and not **میرا**? (ہیں is feminine, and **merā/merī** agrees with the noun's gender.) What does *bhaj-* mean, and is the connection to *bahan* certain? (“To share”; no, it is debated.)

Sources: Wiktionary: **ہیں**.

9.3 تم دوست — “friend,” and the relationship was made for

Back in Chapter 3 you learned three Urdu words for “you” — respectful **āp**, familiar **tum**, intimate **tū** — and were told to use **tum** once a relationship supports familiarity. Here is the relationship that phrase meant.

You'll want to know first — one word

دوست — *dost* — friend

میرا دوست — *merā dost*. — “[He's/She's] my friend.”

Grammar Lens: a noun that will not pick a gender

بھائی was masculine and needed **merā**. بہن was feminine and needed **merī**. دوست breaks the pattern on purpose: it takes **the same form** for a male or a female friend, and **merā dost** works for either. Native Urdu nouns almost always commit to a gender; this Persian loan simply does not carry the machinery that would make it agree.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

dost is Persian, inherited from Old Persian **dauštā**, from Proto-Iranian ***jawštā**, from Proto-Indo-European ***ǵews-**, “to taste, to choose, to enjoy.” That root also gave English **choose** and Latin *gustus* — behind English **gusto**. A friend, on this history, is someone **tasted and chosen**, the same picture as *lenā*’s worn-down “take.” Persian’s own word for “ask,” **porsīdan**, turned out to share one root with Urdu’s inherited پوچھنا. دوست is not that kind of cousin — Urdu has no inherited word from ***ǵews-** to compare it against — but it is the same general shape: an old Indo-European root, arriving in Urdu by the Persian road alone.

Grammar Lens: where تم (tum) actually lives

Chapter 3 taught **āp / tum / tū** and told you to move to **tum** once familiarity is safe. A دوست is exactly that relationship: someone you have moved off **āp** for. You do not need a new rule — just the word for the person the old rule was describing.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **dost** — friend; then **merā dost**, for either a man or a woman
- *Contrast:* **merā bhāī**, **merī bahan**, **merā dost** — two that agree, one that does not
- *Connect:* **dost** ← ***ǵews-** → English **choose**, **gusto**
- *Say it:* **āp**, **tum**, **tū** — then name which one fits a دوست

Before you move on

Does دوست change form for a male or female friend? (No — it stays دوست either way.) Which two English words share دوست's root? (Choose and gusto.) Which of āp / tum / tū fits a دوست? (tum.)

Sources: Wiktionary: دوست.

9.4 خاندان — “family,” the word your three new nouns never needed

Three people-words so far: **bhāī**, **bahan**, **dost** — a specific brother, a specific sister, a specific friend. Not one of them names the group they belong to.

You'll want to know first — one word

خاندان — *khāndān* — family

میرا خاندان — *merā khāndān*. — “[This is] my family.”

خاندان is grammatically masculine, so **merā** stays unchanged — the same class as بھائی.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

خاندان is Classical Persian, borrowed into Urdu whole. Unlike حافظ خدا, whose Persian *khudā* and Arabic-rooted *hāfiz* this book could pull apart piece by piece, no source here commits to what خاندان is built from internally — so this one stays a single unanalyzed loan, not a compound to take apart.

Line up this chapter's four nouns by where they came from. بھائی and بہن are inherited, straight from Sanskrit, the same road as every kin word before them. دوست and خاندان are Persian, the same road as خدا and حافظ back in Chapter 5. The people you would point to and name stayed native; the words for choosing them as friends and grouping them as family reached outside the language.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **khāndān** — family; then **merā khāndān**
- *Say it:* all four — **bhāī, bahan, dost, khāndān**
- *Sort:* inherited — **bhāī, bahan**; Persian — **dost, khāndān**
- *Choose:* **merā** or **merī** for each of the four

Before you move on

Which two of this chapter's nouns are inherited from Sanskrit, and which two are Persian loans? (بھائی, بہن inherited; خاندان, دوست **Persian**.) Say all four people-words with **merā** or **merī** correctly chosen for each.

Sources: Wiktionary: خاندان.

Chapter 10

Four Words on the Face

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) 👁 eyes (3) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name my ear, nose, eye and mouth in Urdu, notice that *kān* and *nāk* share the same three letters reversed, and read the *nūn* that marks a nasal vowel instead of a spoken consonant.

*Name *kān*, *nāk*, *āñkh* and *munh*, explain the plain *nūn* that nasalizes *āñkh* and *munh* against the dedicated ُ of *maññ* and *hūñ*, and count three settled Indo-European cousins found this chapter — *nāk/nose*, *āñkh/eye* — against *kān*’s honest dead end.*

10.1 کان — “ear,” where the body words start

Say **merā khāndān** — my family, closing the last chapter. This chapter turns from the people around you to the wellbeing check itself: four words for the body, starting with the one you use to hear the question.

You’ll want to know first — one word

کان — *kān* — ear

کان-میرا — *merā kān*. — “my ear.”

کان is masculine, so **merā** keeps the form you already know from بھائی
and خاندان.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

kān continues Sanskrit *karṇa* by way of Prakrit and Apabhramsa *kaṇṇa*. That much is solid. Where *karṇa* itself comes from is not: the trail runs out inside Indo-Aryan, with only a loose, unconfirmed suggestion linking it to Persian  (*kar*), “deaf.” No English cousin, no settled Indo-European root — the same honest dead end ’s *path*-hit two chapters ago.

Notice the pattern from last chapter still holds: **کان** is inherited, straight from Sanskrit, the same road as **بھائی** and **بھن**. **خاندان**, the word that closed that chapter, was Persian instead — the body’s own words stay native even where their history goes quiet.

Your turn

- Say it: **kān** — ear; then **merā kān**
- Say it: **khāndān**, then **kān** — one word ends, the body words begin
- Name: what’s uncertain about *karṇa*’s own origin

Before you move on

Is **کان** masculine or feminine? (**Masculine.**) Does *karṇa* have a secure English cousin? (**No — the origin is unsettled.**)
Sources: Wiktionary: **کان**.

10.2 ناک — “nose,” the same three letters as کان, backwards

Say **merā kān** — my ear, masculine, unchanged **merā**. This word shares every letter with it.

You’ll want to know first — one word

ناک — *nāk* — nose

میری ناک — *merī nāk*. — “my nose.”

ناک is feminine — **merī**, not **merā**. Grammatical gender does not follow shape or sound; it has to be learned noun by noun.

The letters in this word

کان is ن اک — *k, ā, n*. ناک is ک ان — *n, ā, k*. The same three letters, in exactly the opposite order. Ear and nose, spelled as mirror images of each other — a coincidence of Urdu’s script, not of its history; the two words are not related.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

nāk continues Sauraseni Prakrit *ṇakka*, from Proto-Indo-Iranian ***náHs**, from Proto-Indo-European ***néh₂s**, “nose.” English **nose** comes from that very root. Where کان’s ancestry ran out unanswered — recall *karṇa*’s own origin was left unsettled last lesson — ناک’s does not: *nāk* and *nose* are genuine cousins, joining بھائی and *brother* as this book’s settled Indo-European matches.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **nāk** — nose; then **merī nāk**
- *Spell:* **kān** forward, then **nāk** — the same three letters, reversed
- *Connect:* **nāk** ← **néh₂s* → English **nose**, real cousins
- *Contrast:* **merā kān** — **merī nāk**

Before you move on

What is the letter relationship between کان and ناک? (**Same three letters, reversed order.**) Is ناک’s English cousin settled or disputed? (**Settled** — *nose* shares its root.) Is ناک masculine or feminine? (**Feminine.**)

Sources: Wiktionary: ناک.

10.3 آنکھ — “eye,” and a fifth letter learns to breathe

Say **merī nāk** — my nose, feminine. The next word on the face is feminine too, and it puts the two-eyed **ه** on a letter it has never touched.

You’ll want to know first — one word

آنکھ — *āṅkh* — eye

آنکھ - میری — *merī āṅkh*. — “my eye.”

The letters in this word

From the right edge: **آ**, alif carrying long *ā* (the same mark you already read in **آپ**), then **ن**, then **ک** *k*, then **ه**.

کھ extends the two-eyed *he* to a fifth base letter. It has already aspirated **ج** in *samajh-*, **ٹ** in *ṭhīk*, **ڑ** in *paṛh-*, and **چ** in *pūchh-*; here it does the same job to **ک**, giving *kh*.

The **ن** in this word is not pronounced as its own consonant. It marks the **آ** before it as nasal — the vowel said through the nose, with no separate *n* sound following it. Say **āṅkh** by nasalizing the *ā*, not by adding a clean *n*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

āṅkh continues Sanskrit *ákṣi*, from Proto-Indo-European ***h₃ek^w-**, “eye, to see.” English **eye** descends from that same root. This chapter has now found two settled Indo-European cousins in a row —

ناک/*nose*, آنکھ/*eye* — after کان’s honest dead end.

Your turn

- Say it: **āṅkh** — eye; then **merī āṅkh**

- *Nasalize*: ā through the nose, no separate n
- *Count*: five letters now carrying ه — ک، چ، ژ، ٹ، ج،
- *Connect*: āṅkh ← *h₃ek^w - → English eye

Before you move on

Which letter does ک newly pair the two-eyed *he* with, and name two letters it already paired with? (ک; any two of ج، ٹ، چ،) What job does ن do in آنکھ? (Marks the ā as nasal — it is not its own consonant.) Is آنکھ's English cousin settled? (Yes — *eye*.) Sources: Wiktionary: آنکھ.

10.4 منہ — “mouth,” and the آنکھ نون already used without explaining

Three face words: kān, nāk, āṅkh — recall that کان and ناک shared the same three letters, reversed. One more word closes the chapter, and it finally explains something آنکھ already did.

You'll want to know first — one word

منہ — *munh* — **mouth** (also: **face**)

میرا منہ — *merā munh*. — “my mouth.”

منہ is masculine.

The letters in this word

From the right edge: م *m*, then ن, then ه, the round *he* you already write in ہوں and ہونا — a real, spoken *h*, not the two-eyed aspirator.

That middle ن does the same job it did in آنکھ, unglossed at the time: it marks the vowel before it as nasal, not a separate *n* sound. Say **muñh** by nasalizing the *u*, with no clean *n* in between.

Keep this apart from میں *main* and ہوں *hūn*, whose nasal ending is written with a different letter entirely: ں, *nūn ghunna*, a dedicated nasalization

mark. منہ and آنکھ nasalize with a plain ن doing double duty; میں and ہوں nasalize with ں, a letter built for exactly that job and nothing else. Same sound, two different letters, depending on which word you are in.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

muñh continues Sanskrit *mūkha*, “mouth, face.” One proposal, from the Sanskrit etymologist Manfred Mayrhofer, ties it to a Proto-Indo-European gesture-root ***mu-**, “pressed lips” — the same root that would sit behind Greek *mýthos* (“word,” behind English **myth**) and German *Maul*, “mouth.” Mayrhofer himself calls a non-Indo-European origin less likely but does not rule it out. Hold this one the way you held بہن’s link to *bhāj-* — a real proposal, not a verdict.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **muñh** — mouth; then **merā muñh**
- *Contrast:* plain ن nasalizing in **āñkh** and **muñh**; ں *nūn ghunna* nasalizing in **main** and **hūn**
- *Say it:* four face words now — **kān**, **nāk**, **āñkh**, **muñh**
- *Connect:* **muñh** possibly ← **mu-* → Greek **mýthos** → English **myth**, held loosely

Before you move on

Which earlier word in this chapter used a plain نون for nasalization the same way منہ does? (آنکھ.) Which letter does میں use instead? (ں, *nūn ghunna*.) Is منہ’s link to Greek *mýthos* certain? (No — a **proposal, held loosely**.)
Sources: Wiktionary: منہ.

Chapter 11

The Heart

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can name my heart in Urdu and trace dil to the same Indo-European root as Sanskrit hṛdaya and English heart, arriving by the Persian road instead of the Sanskrit one.

*Say merā dil, and trace it through Middle Persian and Proto-Iranian back to the same PIE *kērd- that gives Sanskrit hṛdaya, English heart, Latin cor and Greek kardía — dil and hṛdaya split at the Indo-Iranian fork, not opposite lineages but the same root by two roads, echoing pūchhnā and porsīdan.*

11.1 دل — “heart,” Persian, and still a cousin of the English word

Recall منہ: its plain ن marked a nasal vowel, and its possible tie to Greek *mýthos* was held loosely. Recall also پوچھنا: one root, two roads into Urdu — inherited *pūchhnā* and borrowed *pursish*, cousins by two different paths. This chapter’s single word runs that same two-roads shape one level deeper, on the body’s most-named part.

You’ll want to know first — one word

دل — *dil* — heart

دل-میرا — *merā dil*. — “my heart.”

دل is masculine.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

دل is Persian — borrowed into Urdu from Middle Persian *dil*, by the same road as ذل back in Chapter 5. But unlike ذل, whose Sanskrit side this book never named, دل has one, and it is worth naming precisely. Middle Persian *dil* is itself **inherited**, not borrowed, within the Iranian branch of Indo-Iranian: from Proto-Iranian ***jārd**, from Proto-Indo-Iranian ***j^hārd**, from Proto-Indo-European ***kērd-**, “heart.” That is the exact same root behind **Sanskrit** *hṛdaya*, English **heart**, Latin **cor** (behind *courage*, *cordial*), and Greek **kardía** (behind *cardiac*).

So دل and Sanskrit’s word for heart are not opposites, and they did not arrive by accident on the same idea. They are the **same PIE root**, split at the Indo-Iranian fork: one branch went east into Sanskrit and became *hṛdaya*; the other went west into Iranian and became *dil*, then travelled back into Urdu as a loan. Persian and Sanskrit both keep the family’s heart-word — Urdu just happens to have taken the Iranian branch’s copy.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **dil** — heart; then **merā dil**
- *Say it:* the four PIE cousins so far — **bhāī/brother**, **nāk/nose**, **āṅkh/eye**, **dil/heart**
- *Trace it:* **dil** ← Middle Persian ← Proto-Iranian ← PIE ***kērd-** → Sanskrit **hṛdaya**
- *Say it:* one root, two roads — Iranian and Indo-Aryan, the same shape as **pūchhnā/pursish**

Before you move on

Is دل’s resemblance to Sanskrit *hṛdaya* a coincidence, like پسند and *candēre*? (No — **both come from PIE *kērd-*, real cousins.**)

Which branch of Indo-Iranian gave Urdu دل, and which gave Sanskrit **hṛdaya**? (**Iranian; Indo-Aryan.**) Name three other

English words from the same root as دل. (**Heart, cardiac, courage** or **cordial**.)

Sources: Wiktionary: دل.

Chapter 12

Water, Tea, Milk, Bread

Modes: ⇨ voice (2) 👁 eyes (2) ⇨ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name water, tea, milk and bread in Urdu, say what I like using the frame Chapter 8 built, and sort each word as inherited or Persian.

Say mujhe roṭī pasand hai, reusing Chapter 8’s dative-experiencer frame on a plain noun instead of an infinitive, and sort pānī/dūdh/roṭī as inherited against chāy’s Persian loan — with pānī reusing lenā’s verb frame and dūdh correcting a tempting false cognate with English dough.

12.1 پانی — “water,” and لینا put back to work

Say **merā dil** — my heart, closing the body words, and recall that its PIE root reached Urdu by the Persian road while the same root reached Sanskrit’s *hrdaya* by a different one. This chapter turns to the four things you would actually ask for. لینا, “to take,” from three chapters back, gets its first real use since it was taught.

You’ll want to know first — one word

پانی — *pānī* — **water**

پانی is masculine.

Grammar Lens: naming what you'd take

لیتا پانی میں — *maiñ pānī letā hūñ.* — I take/get
water (man speaking). لیتی پانی میں — *maiñ pānī letī*
hūñ. — I take/get water (woman speaking).

لینا's stem **le-** slots a noun in front of it the same way any transitive verb does. You already hold the whole verb; پانی is the first noun you have had to put in front of it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

pānī continues Sanskrit *pānīya*, “water, drink,” built on **pā-**, “to drink,” from Proto-Indo-European ***peh₃-**. English **water** is unrelated — it comes from an entirely different PIE root. But ***peh₃-** itself did reach English, by a different door: Latin *potare*, “to drink,” gave English **potion** and, by way of a sense narrowed to “a poisoned drink,” **poison**. پانی is, underneath, “the drinkable thing” — the same idea English kept for what you drink, not for the substance itself.

Your turn

- Say it: **pānī** — water; then **merā pānī**
- Say it: **maiñ pānī letā hūñ**, then **maiñ pānī letī hūñ**
- Connect: **pānī** ← **pā-** → Latin *potare* → English **potion**, **poison** — not **water**

Before you move on

Is پانی related to English **water**? (**No.**) Name two English words that do share its root. (**Potion** and **poison**.) Say “I take/get water,” once as a man would, once as a woman would.

Sources: Wiktionary: پانی.

12.2 چائے — “tea,” which walked to Urdu rather than sailed

Say **merā pānī** — my water, underneath just “the drinkable thing.” Here is the drink you would politely ask for right after it, and a letter from Chapter 9 makes a second appearance.

You’ll want to know first — one word

چائے — *chāy* — tea

میری چائے — *merī chāy*. — “my tea.”

چائے is feminine.

The letters in this word

From the right edge: چ *ch*, already yours from *sochnā* and *samajhnā*; then / long *ā*; then ی, hamza-ye, the vowel-glide letter بھائی introduced; then ے, broad final *e* from *kaise*. چائے’s ی does the same job it did in بھائی: keeping *ā* and the vowel after it from colliding.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

چائے is borrowed from Classical Persian چای (*chāy*), which traces back to Northern Chinese **chá**, carried overland through Central Asia into Persian before Urdu ever had it. That is the same road خدا and دل travelled in earlier chapters — Persian into Urdu — just with a Chinese starting point this time instead of one further west.

Tea that instead reached Europe by **sea** kept a different form, from southern coastal Chinese, which is why English says **tea** and French says *thé* instead of *chai*. One drink, two words, sorted by whether it travelled by land or by water.

Your turn

- Say it: **chāy** — tea; then **merī chāy**
- Name: the hamza-ye letter’s two words so far — **bhāī**, **chāy**

- *Say it:* the road — chá ... chāy ... chāy
- *Contrast:* merā pānī — merī chāy

Before you move on

Which three languages did چائے pass through, in order? (**Chinese, then Persian, then Urdu.**) Why does English say “tea” instead of “chai”? (**It arrived by sea, carrying a different Chinese form.**) Which earlier Urdu word already used the hamza-ye letter? (بھائی.)

Sources: Wiktionary: چائے.

12.3 دودھ — “milk,” and a false friend worth naming before you fall for it

Say **merī chāy** — my tea, which walked overland from China through Persian before reaching Urdu. This word is what turns it milky, and it hands the two-eyed د a sixth letter to aspirate.

You’ll want to know first — one word

دودھ — *dūdh* — milk

میرا دودھ — *merā dūdh*. — “my milk.”

دودھ is masculine.

The letters in this word

From the right edge: د *d*, then و carrying long *ū*, then د again, then د. د extends the two-eyed *he* to a sixth base letter: it has now aspirated, ج, ٹ, ج, ٹ, and here it aspirates د, giving *dh*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

dūdh continues Sanskrit *dugdhá*, literally “milked,” from Proto-Indo-European ***d^hewg^h-**, “to be fit, to yield, to produce.” That root also gives Sanskrit **duh-**, “to milk” — the verb sitting

directly under this noun.

Here is the trap. English **dough** looks like the obvious match, and it is **not**: *dough* comes from a completely different PIE root, **d^heigh-*, “to knead, to form” — the root behind the shape of bread, not the substance of milk. The real English cousin of **दूध** is a quieter word: **doughty**, “brave, capable,” from the very same **d^hewg^h-*, “fit for, of use.” A doughty person and milked milk share an ancestor; bread dough does not.

Your turn

- *Say it*: **dūdh** — milk; then **merā dūdh**
- *Count*: six letters now carrying **ह** — **द, क, च, ङ, ट, ज**
- *Reject*: **दूध** is NOT related to English **dough**
- *Connect*: **दूध** ← **d^hewg^h-* → English **doughty**, the real cousin

Before you move on

Which English word looks like a match for **दूध** but is not one? (**Dough**.) Which English word actually is the cousin? (**Doughty**.) What Sanskrit verb sits directly under **दूध**? (**duh-**, “to milk.”) Sources: Wiktionary: **दूध**; Etymonline: doughty.

12.4 **रोटी** — “bread,” and **پسند** closes the chapter

Three drinks so far: **pānī**, **chāy**, **dūdh** — and recall **दूध**’s real English cousin was **doughty**, not the tempting **dough**. This chapter’s fourth and final word is the one you would eat, not drink.

You’ll want to know first — one word

रोटी — *roṭī* — bread

میری روٹی — *merī roṭī*. — “my bread.”

روٹی is feminine.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

roṭī continues Sauraseni Prakrit *roṭṭa-*, from Sanskrit *roṭikā*, “a kind of bread.” That word is built inside Sanskrit itself, on a root meaning “to **strike, to crush**” — the pounding and rolling that turns grain into flatbread. The trail stops there: no proposed Proto-Indo-European ancestor, no English cousin. پڑھنا and کان hit the same honest wall earlier in this book. Not every word gets a Greek or Latin relative, and saying so plainly is better than inventing one.

Grammar Lens: ہے پسند ... مجھے, one more time

میں — ہے پسند روٹی مجھے — *mujhe roṭī pasand hai.* — I like bread.

The dative-experiencer frame from Chapter 8 was built for **-nā** infinitives — *paṛhnā, likhnā*. It works just as well for a plain noun: whatever pleases you sits in the subject slot, and ہے agrees with it, not with you.

Your turn

- Say it: **roṭī** — bread; then **merī roṭī**
- Say it: **mujhe roṭī pasand hai**, then swap in **pānī**, then **dūdh**
- Sort: inherited — **pānī, dūdh, roṭī**; Persian — **chāy**
- Say it: all four foods with **merā** or **merī** correctly chosen

Before you move on

Does روٹی have a secure English cousin? (No — **the trail stops at Sanskrit.**) Of this chapter’s four foods, which one is the Persian loan? (چائے.) Say “I like bread” using the frame from Chapter 8.
Sources: Wiktionary: روٹی.

Chapter 13

Four Colors

Modes: ⇄ voice (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name red, white, black and blue in Urdu, and tell which colors change their ending for the noun they describe and which never do.

Say all four colors — لال, سفید, کالا, نیلا — sorting the two that agree with the noun’s gender from the two that never change, and trace نیلا’s cousin nīlī forward through Persian and Arabic into English aniline.

13.1 لال — “red,” and a word that never changes shape

Recall روٹی — bread, an honest dead end with no English cousin. This lesson opens a new kind of word: colors, starting with the one you’d use for a ripe tomato or a bride’s dress.

You’ll want to know first — one word

لال — lāl — red

ہے۔ لال کوٹ میرا — merā koṭ lāl hai. — “My coat is red.”

Grammar Lens: a color that never agrees

لال ends in a consonant, not in ^l. That matters: it stays لال whether the thing it describes is masculine or feminine, singular or plural. *merā kamīz lāl hai, merī ṭopī lāl hai* — same word, no change. Not every color in this book will be this simple.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

لال is borrowed from Classical Persian لال, “red.” No further ancestor is documented for the Persian word itself — the trail simply stops, the same honest kind of dead end روتی’s Sanskrit root hit last lesson, except this time on the Persian side of the book’s two layers rather than the inherited one.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **lāl** — red; then **merā koṭ lāl hai**
- *Note:* لال never changes its ending, unlike the colors still to come
- *Connect:* **lāl** ← Persian, no further root — like روتی’s Sanskrit root, but on the other side of the book’s two layers

Before you move on

What does لال mean, and which layer does it belong to — inherited or Persian? (**Red; Persian.**) Does لال change its ending for a feminine noun? (**No — it stays لال.**) Does لال have a documented ancestor before Persian? (**No — an honest dead end.**) Is خدا حافظ written as one word or two in Urdu spelling? (**Two, spaced — unlike Persian’s joined form.**) When you read ہے ... نام میرا right to left, does the spoken order of the words change? (**No — the script direction changes, the spoken order does not.**)
Sources: Wiktionary: لال.

13.2 سفید — “white,” and English joins the family this time

Recall لال — red, Persian, and a dead end. This word is also Persian, also ends in a consonant, and also never changes shape. But its root does not stop where لال’s did.

You’ll want to know first — one word

سفید — *safed* — **white**

— ہے سفید ٹوپی میری — *merī ṭopī safed hai.* — “My cap is white.”

Like سفید, لال never changes its ending.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

سفید continues Middle Persian *spēt*, from Old Iranian **spaita-*, from Proto-Indo-Iranian **ćwaytás*, from Proto-Indo-European **kweyt-*, “to shine, white.” That is the **exact same root** behind Sanskrit *śvetá*, “white” — so سفید and Sanskrit’s word for white split at the Indo-Iranian fork, one road east into Sanskrit, one road west into Iranian and then Urdu, the same shape as دل and *hṛdaya* two chapters back.

This time a third road leads somewhere new: that same PIE root, through Proto-Germanic, gives English **white** as well. پوچھنا and *porsīdan* were cousins by two roads; سفید, *śvetá*, and **white** are cousins by three.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **safed** — white; then **merī ṭopī safed hai**
- *Contrast:* لال — Persian, dead end; سفید — Persian, and the root keeps going
- *Trace it:* **safed** ← Middle Persian ← PIE **kweyt-* → Sanskrit *śvetá* → English **white**
- *Say it:* one root, three roads this time, not two

Before you move on

What does سفید mean? (**White.**) Name its two settled cousins in other languages. (**Sanskrit śvetá; English white.**) Recall ٹھیک and how a short Urdu word once bridged to a Hindi cognate — how is that bridge different from what سفید just did? (ٹھیک’s bridge was Urdu-to-Hindi, the same modern language pair; سفید’s is a PIE root three languages deep.) How did the earlier take-leave dialogue end? (**With حافظ خدا, spoken by both voices.**)
Sources: Wiktionary: سفید, Wiktionary: white.

13.3 کالا — “black,” and the first color that agrees

Recall سفید — white, cousin of Sanskrit śvetá and English **white**, three roads from one PIE root. This word is inherited rather than Persian, and it breaks the “never changes” rule the last two colors kept.

You’ll want to know first — one word

کالا — *kālā* — black

میرا کالا کوٹ ہے۔ — *merā koṭ kālā hai.* — “My coat is black.”

میری کالی ٹوپی ہے۔ — *merī ṭopī kālī hai.* — “My cap is black.”

Grammar Lens: a color that agrees like میرا

کالا ends in / — and a color ending in / changes with the noun it describes, exactly the way **merā/merī** changed for gender back in the family chapter. Masculine stays کالا; feminine becomes کالی. لال and سفید never had to make this choice, because neither one ends in /. Watch for it again on the last color of this chapter.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

کالا is inherited from Sanskrit *kāla*, “black, dark” — so far, the same kind of story as بھائی or آنکھ. But کالا’s root does not continue into Proto-Indo-European at all. It is usually traced instead to Proto-Dravidian **kār-*, “black, to be burnt”: Sanskrit itself borrowed this color word from its Dravidian neighbours, long before any of it reached Urdu. Inherited from Sanskrit, yes — but Sanskrit’s own source sits outside the Indo-European family this book has been tracing.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **kālā** — black, masculine; **kālī** — black, feminine
- *Choose:* **merā koṭ kālā hai** against **merī ṭopī kālī hai**
- *Contrast:* سفید never changes; کالا always agrees
- *Name:* کالا’s root sits outside Indo-European, in Dravidian — unlike every other inherited word so far

Before you move on

What does کالا mean, and what does it become before a feminine noun? (**Black; kālī.**) Is کالا’s ultimate root Indo-European? (**No — Proto-Dravidian, borrowed into Sanskrit.**) Which two colors so far never change their ending? (لال and سفید.) Does حافظ خرا need a verb or an agreement ending to work as a farewell? (**No — speakers use the fixed formula simply as “goodbye,” no conjugation required.**) When choosing kaise or kaisī, whose gender decides the choice — yours, or the person you’re addressing? (**The person you’re addressing.**)

Sources: Wiktionary: کالا.

13.4 نیلا — “blue,” and this book’s fourth color closes the set

Recall کالی/کالا, the color that agrees, against لال, the color that never does. This chapter’s last word decides which kind it is, then does something none of the other three managed: it left Urdu again, centuries later, and became an English word.

You’ll want to know first — one word

نیلا — *nīlā* — blue

ہے۔ نیلا کوٹ میرا — *merā koṭ nīlā hai.* — “My coat is blue.”

نیلی ends in ل, so it agrees exactly like کالا: feminine نیلی.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

نیلا comes from Sanskrit *nīla*, “dark blue.” No further root is documented behind it — an honest dead end backward, unlike کالا’s root, which kept going sideways into Dravidian. But Sanskrit’s related word *nīlī*, “the indigo plant,” did not stop there. It travelled forward: into Persian *nīla*, then Arabic **an-nīl** (“the indigo”), then Portuguese **anil**, and finally into English as **aniline**, the name nineteenth-century chemists gave the dye compound first found in indigo. سفید reached English through a shared PIE root, inherited by both languages independently. نیلا’s route to English is a completely different shape: one word, borrowed forward through four languages, arriving in English only a couple of centuries ago.

Your turn

- Say it: **nīlā** — blue, masculine; **nīlī** — blue, feminine
- Sort: agrees — کالا, نیلا; never changes — سفید, لال
- Trace it: **nīlā**’s cousin **nīlī** → Persian → Arabic **an-nīl** → Portuguese **anil** → English **aniline**
- Say it: all four colors — سفید, لال, کالا, نیلا — with ٹوپی or کوٹ

Before you move on

Which two of this chapter's four colors agree with the noun they describe, and which two never change? (**Agree:** کالا, نیلا. **Never change:** سفید, لال.) What English word ultimately comes from the same root as نیلا's cousin nālī? (**Aniline.**) Recall the phrase that closed a first introduction with a pleased response — say it now.

(بہوتی خوشی کر مل سے آپ) Does Urdu spell حافظ خدا joined, the way Persian does, or spaced? (**Spaced.**) Reading ہے ... نام میرا right to left changes which direction — the script's, or the spoken word order's? (**Only the script's.**)

Sources: Wiktionary: نیلا, Etymonline: aniline.

Chapter 14

Four Things You Wear

Modes: ⇄ voice (2) 👁 eyes (2) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a shirt, shoe, cap and coat in Urdu, and sort each word by which direction it was borrowed: into Urdu, out of Urdu into English, or straight from English.

Name قمیض, جوتا, ٹوپی and کوٹ, then sort all four by the direction their loan travelled: Persian and Arabic into Urdu, Urdu out into English, or English straight into Urdu — three directions in one small set of words.

14.1 قمیض — “shirt,” and a word that meets its English cousin in a wardrobe

Recall نیلا’s long trip forward into English **aniline**. This lesson opens a new chapter — four things you wear — and its first word makes an even stranger connection than blue did.

You’ll want to know first — one word

قمیض — *qamīz* — shirt

نیلی قمیض میری ہے۔ — *merī qamīz nīlī hai.* — “My shirt is blue.”

قمیض is feminine — that is why نیلا becomes نیلی here.

The letters in this word

From the right edge: ق, م, ی, ض.

ق *qāf* is a new letter, said with the back of the tongue drawn further back in the throat than ک *kāf* — in relaxed speech many speakers merge the two, but careful and formal pronunciation keeps them apart. ض *zād* is also new: like ظ, already known from حافظ, it represents the plain **z** sound in Urdu, even though Arabic once told the two letters apart. Urdu keeps both spellings without keeping the sound distinction Arabic makes.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

قمیض is borrowed from Classical Persian *qamīs*, from Arabic **qamīṣ**, probably from Latin **camisia**, from Proto-West Germanic ***hamiþi**, from Proto-Indo-European ***kām-**, “cover, clothes.” That same Latin **camisia** also gives French **chemise**, borrowed straight into English as **chemise**. Two roads out of one Late Latin word: one east through Arabic and Persian into Urdu, one north through French into English — and both landed, centuries later, meaning a piece of clothing worn on the upper body.

Your turn

- Say it: **qamīz** — shirt; then **merī qamīz nīlī hai**
- Name: ق and ض, the two new letters, and what each is close to — ک and ظ
- Connect: **qamīz** ← Latin **camisia** → English **chemise**, two roads, one Late Latin source
- Say it: قمیض نیلی — a blue shirt

Before you move on

What does قمیض mean, and is it masculine or feminine? (Shirt; feminine.) Which English word probably shares قمیض's Latin

source? (**Chemise.**) What does ہے؟ کیا نام کا آپ ask, and which word is fixed there regardless of who is asked? (“**What is your name?**”; کا, in this frame.) Name the two new letters in this word and one letter each is close to. (ظ, close to ک; ض, close to ق.)
Sources: Wiktionary: قمیض, Wiktionary: chemise.

14.2 جوتا — “shoe,” a cousin of yoke, and a cousin of yoga too

Recall قمیض and its long-shot cousin English **chemise**. This word’s English cousin is even closer, and its Sanskrit cousin is a word you likely already know.

You’ll want to know first — one word

جوتا — *jūtā* — shoe

ہے۔ کالا جوتا میرا — *merā jūtā kālā hai.* — “My shoe is black.”

جوتا is masculine — that is why کالا stays काल here rather than becoming काली.

The letters in this word

From the right edge: ا, ت, و, ج.

ت *te* is new, and it shares its base shape with ٹ, already known from ٹھیک: the same scoop, but ت carries two dots above where ٹ carries a small raised loop instead. Two dots make it plain dental *t*; the loop makes it the retroflex *ṭ* the tongue curls back for.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

jūtā continues Sauraseni Prakrit *jutta*, “joined,” from Sanskrit *yukta*, “joined, yoked,” from Proto-Indo-European ***yewg-**, “to yoke.” That root gives English **yoke** directly, the wooden bar that joins two oxen.

It also gives Sanskrit its own word **yoga** — literally “a joining, a yoking” — the same root, kept inside one language this time rather than split across two. **जुता** keeps the oldest, plainest sense: a thing joined onto the foot.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **jūtā** — shoe; then **merā jūtā kālā hai**
- *Contrast:* **त**, two dots, plain *t*; **ट**, raised loop, retroflex *ṭ*
- *Connect:* **jūtā** ← *yukta* ← PIE **yewg-* → English **yoke**, and → Sanskrit’s own **yoga**
- *Say it:* **قمیض نیلی** and **جوتا کالا** together

Before you move on

What does **जुता** mean, and is it masculine or feminine? (**Shoe; masculine.**) Name **जुता**’s two English-family cousins. (**Yoke, and Sanskrit’s own yoga.**) What marks **त** apart from the already-known **ट**? (**Two dots above, instead of a raised loop.**) When asking how someone is, does **kaise/kaisī** agree with your own gender or the gender of the person you’re asking? (**The person you’re asking.**) Recall **ٹھیک**’s Hindi bridge — does it come before or after you can already read the Urdu form yourself? (**After.**) What line closes the take-leave dialogue this book opened early on? (**حافظ خرا, spoken by both voices.**)
Sources: Wiktionary: **जुता**, Wiktionary: *yukta*.

14.3 **ٹولی** — “cap,” a dead end behind it, a loan ahead of it

Recall **जुता**, cousin of English **yoke** and Sanskrit **yoga**. This word has no such cousin behind it — but it made one of its own, going the other direction.

You'll want to know first — one word

ٹوپی — *ṭopī* — cap, hat

میرے سفید ٹوپی ہے — *merī ṭopī safed hai*. — “My cap is white.”

ٹوپی is feminine, like روٹی and قمیض.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ٹوپی is inherited from Sauraseni Prakrit *ṭopiā*, “helmet,” related to Sanskrit *ṭopikā*. No further root is documented behind that — another honest dead end, like روٹی and کان.

But ٹوپی did something those two never did: it left Urdu and Hindi and became an English word. **Topee**, first recorded in English between 1825 and 1835, is borrowed directly from Hindi *ṭopī*, “hat” — the lightweight sun hat worn across British India. نیلا's cousin *nīlī* took four languages and a chemistry lab to become English *aniline*. ٹوپی simply walked straight into English as itself.

Your turn

- Say it: **ṭopī** — cap; then **merī ṭopī safed hai**
- Name: ٹوپی's own root stops at Prakrit — a dead end, like روٹی
- Connect: **ṭopī** → English **topee**, borrowed directly, no intermediate language
- Say it: جوتا کالا and سفید ٹوپی together

Before you move on

What does ٹوپی mean, and is it masculine or feminine? (**Cap/hat; feminine.**) Does ٹوپی have a documented root before Prakrit? (**No — a dead end.**) What English word borrows ٹوپی directly, and

roughly when? (**Topee, 1825–35.**) Recall the frame that put ٹھیک inside a full sentence — say it now with میں. (ہوں۔ ٹھیک میں) Does حافظ خدا need a conjugated verb to work as a farewell? (No — it’s used as a fixed formula, no agreement ending required.)
Sources: Wiktionary: ٹپلی, Dictionary.com: topee.

14.4 کوٹ — “coat,” and every direction a loan can travel

Recall this chapter’s three words: قیض, borrowed from Arabic through Persian; جوتا, inherited all the way from Proto-Indo-European; ٹپلی, borrowed out of Urdu into English as topee. This chapter’s last word takes the shortest road of all.

You’ll want to know first — one word

کوٹ — koṭ — coat

ہے۔ نیلا کوٹ میرا — merā koṭ nīlā hai. — “My coat is blue.”

کوٹ is masculine.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

کوٹ is borrowed directly from English **coat** — a modern loan, one generation old rather than a thousand years. It happens to look identical to an older, unrelated کوٹ meaning “fort,” inherited from Sanskrit koṭṭa — the two are homographs, not cousins, and the spelling gives no warning either way.

This book has named two layers before now: the inherited Indo-Aryan core, and the Persian-Arabic literary layer borrowed centuries ago.

کوٹ is the first clear example of a **third** layer — everyday English

loans, arriving through more recent contact. And this chapter has now shown every direction a loanword can travel in one small set of four:

Persian and Arabic *into* Urdu (قمیض), Urdu straight *out* into English (ٹوپی), and English straight *into* Urdu (کوٹ).

Your turn

- *Say it:* koṭ — coat; then merā koṭ nīlā hai
- *Name:* three layers now — inherited, Persian-Arabic, and modern English
- *Sort:* قمیض in, ٹوپی out, کوٹ in — three loans, three directions
- *Say it:* all four clothing words — قمیض, جوتا, ٹوپی, کوٹ — each with a color from the earlier chapter

Before you move on

What does کوٹ mean, and where does it come from? (Coat; **borrowed directly from English.**) Which of this chapter's four words was borrowed *out of* Urdu rather than into it? (ٹوپی, **into English as topee.**) Recall the farewell that closes almost any Urdu conversation — say it now. (حافظ خدا.) What does the standard reply to the wellbeing question say about the speaker? (ٹھیک میں)

شکریہ ہوں، — “I am fine, thank you.”)

Sources: Wiktionary: کوٹ.

Chapter 15

Rain, Sun, Wind, Heat, Cold

Modes: ⇨ voice (4) 👁 eyes (1) ⇨ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name rain, sunshine, wind, heat and cold in Urdu, and tell which of these words' roots reach back to a documented ancestor and which stop at an honest dead end.

Say all five weather words in one breath and sort each by how far its root reaches: two Persian dead ends, one inherited dead end, one loan of a loan, and گرمی's own root reaching all the way to Greek thermós — the same two-roads shape دل showed on the body's most-named part.

15.1 بارش — “rain,” and why you’d wear the last chapter’s coat

Recall کوٹ, the modern English loan that closed the last chapter. This chapter gives you a reason to wear it: four words for weather, the small talk that follows almost any “how are you.”

You’ll want to know first — one word

بارش — *bārish* — rain

ہے۔ رہی ہو بارش — *bārish ho rahī hai.* — “It’s raining.”

بارش is feminine.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

بارش is borrowed from Classical Persian **bāriš**, itself built from **bār**, “load, downpour,” plus the ending **-eš** that turns a verb or noun stem into an action noun. No further Proto-Indo-European root is documented behind that Persian base — an honest dead end, the same shape as لال’s.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **bāriš** — rain; then **bāriš ho rahī hai**
- *Name:* بارش’s two Persian parts — **bār** plus the **-eš** ending
- *Connect:* بارش’s dead end is the same shape as لال’s — Persian, and no further
- *Say it:* کوٹ میرا لیے اس ہے، بارش آج — “Today there’s rain, so I need my coat.”

Before you move on

What does بارش mean, and is it masculine or feminine? (**Rain; feminine.**) What two Persian pieces build the word? (**bār, “load/downpour,” plus the -eš ending.**) Recall the three respect levels a single Urdu word for “you” once had to distinguish — name them. (**āp, tum, tū.**) Which letter in حافظ carries the *f* sound? (**ف.**)
Sources: Wiktionary: بارش.

15.2 دھوپ — “sunshine,” rain’s opposite and its etymological twin

Recall بارش — rain, Persian, and a dead end. This word means the opposite in the sky, and reaches a dead end from the other side of the book’s two layers.

You'll want to know first — one word

دھوپ — *dhūp* — sunshine

آج دھوپ ہے۔ — *āj dhūp hai.* — “There’s sunshine today.”

دھوپ is feminine.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

دھوپ is inherited from Ashokan Prakrit **dhuppā*, “sunshine.” No further root is documented behind that. بارش hit its dead end on the Persian side; دھوپ hits the same kind of honest wall on the inherited side — the same shape کان and روٹی already showed, not every inherited word traces back to a tidy Indo-European root.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **dhūp** — sunshine; then **āj dhūp hai**
- *Contrast:* بارش, Persian dead end; دھوپ, inherited dead end — opposite weather, same kind of etymological wall
- *Name:* two other inherited dead ends already met — کان and روٹی
- *Say it:* آج بارش ہے یا دھوپ؟ — “Is it rain today, or sunshine?”

Before you move on

What does دھوپ mean, and is it masculine or feminine? (**Sunshine; feminine.**) Is دھوپ’s root documented past Prakrit? (**No — a dead end.**) Recall whether حافظ خدا is written as one word or two in Urdu spelling. (**Two, spaced, unlike Persian’s joined form.**) What does آنکھ mean? (**Eye.**)
Sources: Wiktionary: دھوپ.

15.3 ہوا — “wind,” a loan carried twice rather than split once

Recall دھوپ — sunshine, an inherited dead end. This word moves with the sunshine and the rain both, and its history takes a shape this book has not shown yet: not two roads from one root, but one word handed across two borrowings in a row.

You’ll want to know first — one word

ہوا — *hawā* — air, wind

آج رہی چل ہوا ہے — *āj hawā chal rahī hai*. — “There’s wind blowing today.”

ہوا is feminine.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ہوا is borrowed from Classical Persian *hawā* — but Persian did not invent it either. Persian itself borrowed the word from Arabic هَوَاء *hawā*. خدا, back in the take-leave chapter, came into Urdu directly from Persian, inherited within Iranian the whole way. سفید and دل each split from one PIE root into two independent roads, Iranian and Indo-Aryan. ہوا is a different shape again: a single word passed hand to hand, Arabic to Persian, Persian to Urdu — a loan of a loan, not a shared inheritance at all.

Your turn

- Say it: **hawā** — wind; then **āj hawā chal rahī hai**
- Name: three shapes a word’s history can take — one root split two ways (دل), a word carried straight through one language (خدا), or borrowed twice in a row (ہوا)
- Say it: ہوا اور دھوپ، بارش — rain, sunshine, and wind
- Connect: ہوا ← Persian ← Arabic **hawā**, a loan of a loan

Before you move on

What does ہوا mean, and is it masculine or feminine? (Air, wind; feminine.) How is ہوا's history different from دل's? (دل split from one root into two roads; ہوا is one word borrowed twice in a row.) Name your sister and your friend in Urdu. (بہن; دوست.)

Sources: Wiktionary: ہوا.

15.4 گرمی — “heat,” a secure cousin and a disputed one

Recall ہوا — wind, a loan of a loan. This word is Persian too, but its root behaves like دل's and سفید's: it keeps going back to a shared PIE root, with a genuine cousin waiting on the other side — though this time the cousin needs a careful claim, not a confident one.

You'll want to know first — one word

گرمی — *garmī* — heat

ہے۔ گرمی بہت آج — *āj bahut garmī hai.* — “It's very hot today.”

گرمی is feminine.

The letters in this word

From the right edge: ی, م, ر, گ.

گ *gāf* is new: it is ک *kāf*, already known, with one extra stroke laid across the top — the same dot-count logic that separated ب from پ, except this time the letter gains a stroke rather than a dot.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

گرمی continues Middle Persian *garmīh*, from Proto-Iranian **garmáh*, from Proto-Indo-Iranian **g^harmás*, from Proto-Indo-European **g^{wh}er-*, “warm.” That root securely gives Greek **thermós**, “hot” — the source of English **thermal** and **thermometer**. English **warm** is often mentioned beside it, but dictionaries only call **warm** a “distant doublet” of *thermós*: a proposed relative, not a settled one, with a separate and more likely Germanic root offered as **warm**’s real source.

گرمی’s certain family is Greek’s, not English’s plainest weather word.

Your turn

- Say it: **garmī** — heat; then **āj bahut garmī hai**
- Name: گ’s relation to ک — one extra stroke, not a dot
- Sort: secure cousin — Greek **thermós**; disputed cousin — English **warm**
- Say it: گرمی ہوا، دھوپ، بارش — all four weather words so far

Before you move on

What does گرمی mean, and is it masculine or feminine? (**Heat; feminine.**) Which English word is گرمی’s secure cousin, and which is only disputed? (**Secure: thermal/thermometer, via Greek thermós. Disputed: warm.**) Name your family in Urdu. (خاندان.) What does منہ mean? (**Mouth.**)

Sources: Wiktionary: گرمی, Wiktionary: warm.

15.5 سردی — “cold,” and one ending that ties this whole book’s weather and warmth together

Recall گرمی — heat, with a secure cousin in Greek **thermós** and only a disputed one in English **warm**. This chapter’s last word is its exact opposite, in meaning and in how far its own root travels.

You’ll want to know first — one word

سردی — *sardī* — cold

سردی بہت آج ہے۔ — *āj bahut sardī hai.* — “It’s very cold today.”

سردی is feminine, exactly like گرمی.

Grammar Lens: one ending, two weather words

گرمی and سردی are built the same way: the plain adjective — گرم *garm* “hot,” سرد *sard* “cold” — plus the ending ی that turns it into a noun naming the weather itself. Neither word is a one-off; the ending is a small, reusable tool, the same kind of thing -نا was for verbs many chapters back.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

سردی is borrowed from Classical Persian *sardī*, from *sard*, “cold.” No further root is documented for that Persian base — a dead end, the

same shape as لال’s and بارش’s, and the mirror image of گرمی, whose root reaches all the way to Greek **thermós**.

Five weather words, every shape this book’s etymology has found:

بارش and سردی, Persian dead ends; دھوپ, an inherited dead end; ہوا,

a loan of a loan; گرمی, a root reaching a real if disputed cousin — the same two-roads shape دل showed on the body’s most-named part.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **sardī** — cold; then **āj bahut sardī hai**
- *Contrast:* گرمی, a root reaching Greek; سردی, a Persian dead end
- *Say it:* all four weather words in one breath — ہوا، دھوپ، بارش، سردی گرمی،
- *Recall:* دل's two roads from one PIE root, and how گرمی's own root follows the same shape

Before you move on

What does سردی mean? (**Cold.**) Does its root reach as far as گرمی's? (**No — a Persian dead end.**) Which letter in بھائی marks the glide between two vowels? (ی, **ye with hamza.**) Which two face words share the same three letters reversed? (ناک and کان.)

What job does plain ن do in آنکھ and منہ? (**Marks the vowel before it as nasal.**) What PIE root ties دل to Sanskrit hṛdaya? (***kērd-**, split at the Indo-Iranian fork.)

Sources: Wiktionary: سردی.

Chapter 16

Seven Letters, and the Words You Already Knew

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ✍ pen (8) ⇄ Hands-free start: none of the 9 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can write seven Urdu letters from memory, read salam, kya, kan, nak, lal, kala, nila and lena off the page rather than from the romanization, and explain why Urdu leaves its short vowels unwritten.

Eight words the book had only ever given by ear, read letter by letter from the right – including kan and nak, the same three letters in different orders, which is the proof that the reader is decoding rather than recognising.

16.1 | — one stroke, and a page that runs the other way

You have been reading Urdu words in this book for fifteen chapters and taking their shapes on trust. That stops here.

Script — first, which way the page runs

English marches **left to right**. Urdu marches **right to left**. Your pen starts at the **right edge** of a word and travels **towards the left**, so the letter you meet **first** is the **rightmost** one.

There is a second direction, and it belongs to Urdu in a way it does not belong to Arabic. Urdu is written in a style called **Nastaliq**, and Nastaliq does not sit flat on the line. A word **cascades downward as it moves**

left, each letter hanging a little below the one before it, so a word reads like a short diagonal staircase running down to the left.

That is why Urdu looks different from Arabic even where the letters are the same. It is not decoration and it is not optional: it is how Urdu is set.

Script — the letter itself

ل

One tall downstroke. Draw it from the top down and lift. Nothing else.

Its name is **alif**, and one thing about it matters more than its shape: **alif does not join to the letter that follows it.** Hold that; the next few lessons will make it pay.

Your turn

- *Write it:* ل — one stroke, top to bottom
- *Point to:* at the right edge of an Urdu word, where your pen would begin

Before you move on

How many strokes in alif? (**One.**)

16.2 ل — alif, and then a bowl under the line

Write ل. One stroke, top to bottom.

Script — the shape

ل

Start exactly as you started alif — a tall upright coming down — and then, without lifting, **carry on below the baseline** into a leftward bowl and back up.

One movement, no pen lift. The bowl going **below the line** is the part to get right; it is what tells lām apart from alif at a glance.

Its name is **lām** and it says **l**.

Your turn

- *Write it:* ۱, then ۲ — the same descent, then the bowl below the line
- *Say it:* ۱

Before you move on

Do you lift the pen between the upright and the bowl? (**No.**)

16.3 ۳ — three teeth, then a bowl, without lifting

Write ۳. Upright, then the bowl below the line.

Script — the shape

۳

Three small **teeth** close together — short upward points in a row — and then the line flows straight on into a **bowl** below the baseline.

Remember which way you are working: the first tooth you draw is the **rightmost** one.

No lift anywhere. Teeth and bowl are one continuous movement, and letting the pen stop between them is the commonest way a beginner's sīn comes out looking like two letters.

Its name is **sīn** and it says **s**.

Your turn

- *Write it:* ۳ — three teeth from the right, flowing into the bowl, one movement
- *Say it:* s

Before you move on

Which tooth comes first? (The **rightmost**.)

16.4 — a round head, and a tail under the line

Write . Three teeth, then the bowl, no lift.

Script — the shape



A small **round head** sitting on the line, and from it a **tail** running straight down **below** the baseline.

Keep the head small and closed. Plenty of letters dip below the line — you have already written one in *lām* — but *mīm*'s drop is a **straight tail** hanging off a round head, and that combination is what makes it easy to spot standing alone. Joined into the middle of a word the tail is trimmed away and the head survives.

One movement, no lift.

Its name is **mīm** and it says **m**.

Your turn

- *Write it:*  — the round head, then the tail below the line
- *Say it:* **m**

Before you move on

Is the head open or closed? (**Closed.**)

16.5 Letters that hold hands, and the one that will not

Write , then . Four letters are now yours.

Script — the running, falling line

Urdu letters **join**. They run into one another along a single connected line, and because this is Nastaliq that line is also **falling** — each joined letter sits a little lower and further left than the one before it.

Because they join, most letters **change shape** by position. A letter opening a joined run, one buried in the middle, one closing it, and one standing alone can all look different. They are the same letter.

That sounds like four times the work and it is not, because the change is almost always **the same trimming**: the part that identifies the letter stays, and the finishing flourish is cut short so the next letter can start. You saw it already in mīm, where joining costs the tail and keeps the head.

Script — and the letter that refuses

Now the rule that saves the most confusion.

Some letters take the hand of the letter on their right and offer nothing to the left. The run stops dead after them, and the next letter begins as though starting a fresh word.

alif is one of these. So a gap in the middle of an Urdu word is usually not a word break at all — it is a non-joining letter doing exactly what it always does. Without that fact a page of Urdu looks like it has been spaced at random.

What you've built

Four letters, and they spell the word this book opened with:

سلام

From the right: س *s*, ل *l*, ا *ā*, م *m*. Say it: **salām**.

Two things to see. The short vowel between s and l is **not written** — Urdu prints the long vowels and leaves the short ones to the reader. And the break before the final م is alif refusing to join, exactly as promised.

Your turn

- *Read it:* سلام — name each letter from the right, then say the word
- *Write it:* سلام — let the line fall as it goes, and let it break after alif
- *Say it:* **salām**

Before you move on

What does mīm lose when it joins? (Its **tail**.)

16.6 ک — a bowl with a slash laid over it

Write سلام. Four letters, one break.

Script — the shape

ک

Two movements, and exactly **one** lift between them.

1. a **stem** down, flowing right to left through a **flatter bowl** and finishing with a pronounced **hook** — all without lifting 2. lift once, then a **long slash** drawn down from the upper right towards the stem

The slash is not a dot and not decoration; it is part of the letter, and leaving it off writes nothing at all.

Its name is **kāf** and it says **k**.

Worth knowing: **this is the Urdu kāf**. Arabic writes the same sound with a different shape, and if you have seen Arabic you will notice the difference immediately. Urdu keeps the Perso-Arabic alphabet and does not keep every Arabic shape.

Your turn

- *Write it:* ک — stem, bowl and hook in one movement, then lift and lay the slash across
- *Say it:* **k**

Before you move on

Is the slash optional? (**No** — without it the letter is not written.)

16.7 ن — a deep bowl, and one dot

Write ک. Bowl and hook, lift, slash.

Script — the shape

ن

A **bowl** swept from right to left, dropping well **below the baseline** and rising again — then one lift, and a single **dot** placed near the baseline, inside the curve.

Two parts, one lift. The bowl is deeper and rounder than the flatter one you drew in kāf, and the dot sits low rather than floating above.

Its name is **nūn** and it says **n**.

Your turn

- *Write it:* ن — the deep bowl, then lift and place the dot low inside it
- *Say it:* n

Before you move on

Which bowl is deeper, nūn's or kāf's? (**nūn's.**)

16.8 ی — one S-curve, no dots

Write ن. Deep bowl, lift, low dot.

Script — the shape

ی

Start at the **upper right** and descend through an **S-shaped curve**, then carry on left around a bowl that drops **below the baseline**, and finish at its rising tip.

One movement. No lift, and no dots at all. Standing alone, ye is one of the few letters in this chapter with nothing added to it — no dot, no slash — and that emptiness is how you recognise it.

Its name is **ye**, and it does **three** jobs: the consonant **y**, the long vowel **ī**, and a second long vowel **e**. Which one it is comes from the word, not from the shape — there is nothing on the page to tell them apart.

You will meet all three in this chapter. کیا *kyā* uses the consonant, نیلا *nīlā* uses the long *ī*, and لینا *lenā* uses the *e*. Three words, one letter, three values, and only having heard them tells you which.

Your turn

- *Write it:* ʃ — the S-curve down, round the bowl, and up at the tip
- *Say it:* y, then ī, then e — one letter, three jobs

Before you move on

Can the shape alone tell you which of its three values it carries?
(No — the word tells you.)

16.9 Practice — eight words you already knew, now read

Write your seven letters in a row, right to left, naming each as you go, and let the line fall as it travels.

Script — the words come back

Nothing new is taught here. Every word below was already given to you to say, and every letter in it is one you can now write.

Read each from the right, naming its letters before you say it:

سلام

>

کیا

>

کان

>

ناک

>

لال

>

کالا

>

نیلا

>

لینا

salām — kyā — kān — nāk — lāl — kālā — nīlā — lenā.

Eight words from seven letters. Two of them are worth a second look:

کان *kān* “ear” and ناک *nāk* “nose” use the **same three letters** in different orders, which is the clearest possible proof that you are reading rather than recognising a picture.

Why it’s said this way

Count the letters in کیا and count the sounds in *kyā*.

Urdu writes its long vowels and leaves the short ones off the page. The reader supplies them. That is why *salām* has a vowel between the s and the l that nothing on the page records.

This has a consequence worth accepting now rather than discovering later: **you cannot reliably sound out an Urdu word you have never heard.** Reading and listening have to grow together here, more tightly than in a language that spells every vowel — which is exactly why this book spent fifteen chapters putting these words in your ear before handing you the page.

What you’ve built this chapter

Seven letters, and three ideas that outlast them:

- **the page runs right to left**, and in Nastaliq the word also **falls** as it goes, each letter hanging below the last
- **letters join**, changing shape by position — but the change is a **trimming**, and **alif refuses to join leftward**, which is what puts gaps inside a word

- **what is added matters:** nūn's dot, kāf's slash, and ye's bare curve are the identification, not the decoration

Seven of Urdu's letters. The rest are mostly more of what you just did.

Your turn

- *Read it:* کان and ناک — same three letters, and say which is which
- *Write it:* سلام — and let it break after alif
- *Read it:* لال نیلا کالا — name the letters of each before saying it

Before you move on

Which of your seven letters refuses to join to the left? (l.)

Pronunciation & Script Reference

A **reference**, not a chapter. Use it when a lesson names a sound; do not clear it as an alphabet gate. Urdu script is introduced through useful expressions, with only the shapes and sound contrasts needed on that page.

The track shows a learner romanization beside new Urdu. A line above a vowel marks length ($\bar{a}$, $\bar{i}$), and a tilde marks nasalization ($\tilde{a}$, $\tilde{i}$). Cover the romanization once the Urdu form is familiar.

Script, spelling, and type style

- **Read right to left** (rtl). Start each word at its right edge.
- **Letters usually join** and change shape by position. Some letters, including ل and و in current words, break the connection to the following shape on their left.
- Urdu is an **abjad**: some vowels are unwritten and inferred from the learned word (**short-vowels-unwritten**). Long vowels use letter shapes such as ا , و , and ی ; ـ can carry e/ai .
- Urdu is traditionally printed in **Nastaliq**, whose connected words descend in a flowing slope. The book and app use the vendored static Noto Nastaliq Urdu family, including its Urdu OpenType localization and contextual joins. Naskh remains an accessibility fallback when a learner's browser cannot load the course font; it is no longer the normal presentation.

Sound ids used by the starter lessons

- **Sound id: rtl**
What to do: follow the word from its right edge leftward
First anchor: سلام *salām*
- **Sound id: long-a**
What to do: hold *ā* steady; *l* carries it in سلام
First anchor: سلام *salām*
- **Sound id: alif-madd**
What to do: read *ā* as word-initial long *ā*
First anchor: آپ *āp*
- **Sound id: short-vowels-unwritten**
What to do: supply the learned short vowels even when vowel marks are absent
First anchor: شکریہ *shukriyā*
- **Sound id: long-i**
What to do: hold *ī* as *ī* in this word
First anchor: جی *jī*
- **Sound id: long-u**
What to do: hold *ū* as long *ū* in the learned word
First anchor: ہوں *hūn*
- **Sound id: nasal-vowel**
What to do: let air pass through the nose; final *ṇ* does not add a full English *n*
First anchor: ہاں *hā*, نہیں *nahī*
- **Sound id: long-vowels**
What to do: read the word's written long-vowel cues rather than stretching every vowel
First anchor: نام میرا *merā nām*
- **Sound id: hai-diphthong**
What to do: say *hai* as one *hai* syllable, ending in an *ai* glide
First anchor: ہے *hai*

- **Sound id: sh**
What to do: read three-dotted ش as *sh*
First anchor: شکریہ *shukriyā*
- **Sound id: kh**
What to do: make خ farther back than English *h*
First anchor: خوشی *khushī*
- **Sound id: consonantal-ye**
What to do: let ی supply consonantal *y* before a vowel
First anchor: کیا *kyā*
- **Sound id: ai-diphthong**
What to do: say *ai* as one glide in the learned question word
First anchor: کیسے *kaise*
- **Sound id: final-ye**
What to do: distinguish broad final ے *e* from final ی long *ī*
First anchor: کیسے / کیسی *kaise / kaisī*
- **Sound id: retroflex-aspirated-th**
What to do: curl the tongue slightly back for ٹ, then release the aspiration marked by ہ
First anchor: ٹھیک *ṭhīk*
- **Sound id: urdu-question-mark**
What to do: recognize ؟ at the left end of a right-to-left question
First anchor: ہے؟ کیا نام کا آپ
- **Sound id: be-vs-pe-dots**
What to do: count the dots under the shared low scoop: one below is ب *b*, three below are پ *p*
First anchor: بولنا *bolnā* against آپ *āp*
- **Sound id: geminate-nun**
What to do: hold the *n* long when two ن letters are written in a row
First anchor: جانتا *jānnā*

- **Sound id: che-vs-jim-dots**
What to do: count the dots below the *jīm* body: one is چ *j*, three are چ *ch*
First anchor: سوچنا *sochnā* against جانا *jānā*
- **Sound id: do-chashmi-he**
What to do: give ہ no sound of its own; let it aspirate the letter to its right
First anchor: سمجھنا *samajhnā*, لکھنا *likhnā*
- **Sound id: retroflex-flap-rre**
What to do: flick a curled-back tongue once for ڑ; do not roll it
First anchor: پڑھنا *parhnā*
- **Sound id: majhul-e**
What to do: read medial ی as long *e* where the learned word calls for it
First anchor: لینا *lenā*
- **Sound id: qaf-uvular**
What to do: draw the back of the tongue further back in the throat for ق than for ک; many speakers merge the two in casual speech
First anchor: قیض *qamīz*
- **Sound id: te-dots-vs-tte-loop**
What to do: two dots above make plain dental ت; a small raised loop instead makes retroflex ٹ
First anchor: جوتا *jūtā* against ٹھیک *ṭhīk*
- **Sound id: gaf-stroke**
What to do: گ is ک with one extra stroke laid across the top
First anchor: گرمی *garmī*

Shape families already in use

- س *s* and ش *sh* share a skeleton; three dots distinguish ش.
- ن is consonantal *n*. Final dotless ں is *nūn-e ghunna* and marks nasalization in ہاں and نہیں.

- ی supplies the long $\bar{y}$ in جی and نہیں. Final ے participates in *hai* in ہے. Learn each role in its word before generalizing.
- کیا gives ی its consonantal y job; کیسی / کیسے then contrast broad final ے with long- $\bar{y}$ final ی.
- ٹھیک introduces the Indic retroflex-plus-aspiration sequence ٹھ only when the wellbeing reply needs it.
- حافظ خدا reuses خ and long l , adds a clear initial h in حافظ, and reads final ظ as z . Urdu conventionally keeps the two words visibly spaced, even though Persian normally joins its local spelling.
- بولنا adds the only new consonant the verb chapter needs: ب b , one low scoop with a single dot below. It shares that skeleton with پ p , already read in آپ, which carries three dots below instead. Dot count is the whole difference, and it is load-bearing throughout the alphabet.
- جانا writes two ن letters in a row and pronounces both, which is the only thing separating it from جانا $jānā$. Nothing about the doubling is decorative: جانا is “to go” and جانتا is “to know.”
- چ ch is the ج j body with **three dots below** instead of one — the same dot-count contrast as ب against پ, on a second skeleton.
- ھ is *do-chashmī* he , “two-eyed he.” It is never a consonant on its own; it aspirates whatever letter stands to its right. ٹھیک used it first, and سمجھنا, پڑھنا, پوچھنا and لکھنا use it again in جھ, ڑھ, چھ and کھ. Keep it apart from round ھ *gol* he , which is a real h and is the letter in ہوں and ہونا.
- ر is ر r wearing the small retroflex mark that also rides on ٹ. One diacritic, one instruction — curl the tongue back — now on two letters.
- ی takes a **third** value in لینا $lenā$: a long e . With consonantal y in کیا and long $\bar{y}$ in جی, and broad final ے beside it, the *ye* family covers y , $\bar{y}$ and e ; the learned word decides.

- **ق** *qāf*, first read in **قیض**, shares its throat position with already-known **خ** but is a stop rather than a fricative — a plosive version of the same back-of-the-mouth place. **ض** *zād*, in the same word, joins **ظ** (from **حافظ**) as a second letter carrying the plain **z** sound in Urdu, even though Arabic once told the two apart.
- **ت** *te*, first read in **جوتا**, shares its base scoop with already-known **ٹ**: two dots above make it plain dental *t*, where a small raised loop instead makes **ٹ** retroflex.
- **گ** *gāf*, first read in **گرمی**, is already-known **ک** with one extra stroke laid across the top — the same dot-count logic that told **ب** apart from **پ**, this time with a stroke instead of a dot.

The Persian-Arabic and Indo-Aryan layers

Script does not determine a word's history. **شکریہ** and **سلام** expose the Persian-Arabic literary layer; **نہیں**, **میرا**, **نام**, and **ہے** expose the inherited Indo-Aryan core that Urdu shares with Hindi. Mixed-language practice may use that relationship as a bridge, but the Urdu script remains the assessed form for this track.

Sources

- *Zero Zabar*: How the Urdu script works
- *Zero Zabar*: The Urdu alphabet

Glossary

This glossary collects every word and phrase taught in the book. Pronunciation appears when it differs from the written form; chapter numbers show where each entry is introduced.

آنا *ānā*

to come — literally “go toward,” built from a prefix and the verb for going
Introduced in Chapter 6.

آنکھ *ānikh*

eye — a fifth base letter for the two-eyed he, and another real cousin of an English word
Introduced in Chapter 10.

آپ / تم / تو *āp / tum / tū*

you — respectful / familiar / intimate
Introduced in Chapter 3.

آپ کا نام کیا ہے؟ *āp kā nām kyā hai?*

What is your name? (respectful)
Introduced in Chapter 3.

آپ کیسے ہیں؟ / آپ ہیں؟ کیسے آپ *āp kaise haiñ? / āp kaisī haiñ?*

How are you? — respectfully to a man / woman
Introduced in Chapter 4.

آپ سے مل کر خوشی ہوئی *āp se mil kar khushī huī*

pleased to meet you
Introduced in Chapter 3.

بہن *bahan*

sister — feminine, where بھائی was masculine, and the reason میرا has to change shape
Introduced in Chapter 9.

بارش *bārish*

rain — Persian, built from “load” plus a noun-forming ending, and a dead end behind that
Introduced in Chapter 15.

بھائی *bhāī*

brother — the first noun this book has taught with a real grammatical gender, and a genuine English cousin
Introduced in Chapter 9.

بولنا *bolnā*

to speak — the plain Indo-Aryan verb under Urdu’s Persian and Arabic finery
Introduced in Chapter 6.

چائے *chāy*

tea — Persian again, this time by an overland road from Chinese, and the hamza-ye letter’s second word
Introduced in Chapter 12.

دھوپ *dhūp*

sunshine — inherited, and another honest dead end, like کان and روٹی before it
Introduced in Chapter 15.

دل *dil*

heart — Persian, and a real cousin of English heart by the Iranian road, not the Sanskrit one
Introduced in Chapter 11.

دوست *dost*

friend — a Persian word that refuses to pick a gender, and exactly the relationship تم was made for
Introduced in Chapter 9.

دودھ *dūdh*

milk — a sixth letter learns to breathe, and an English cousin that is NOT the word you’d guess
Introduced in Chapter 12.

گرمی *garmī*

heat — Persian, from the same PIE root as Greek thermós, with English warm only a disputed distant cousin
Introduced in Chapter 15.

حافظ *hāfiz*

guardian, protector — the Arabic-rooted half of the farewell
Introduced in Chapter 5.

ہوا *hawā*

air, wind — Persian, and Persian's own loan from Arabic, a loan of a loan rather than two roads from one root
Introduced in Chapter 15.

ہونا *honā*

to be — and the ending every Urdu verb wears when you name it
Introduced in Chapter 6.

جانا *jānā*

to go — the verb that shows the two agreements an Urdu present tense makes at once
Introduced in Chapter 6.

جاننا *jānnā*

to know — the Urdu cousin of English know, Latin notice, and Greek gnosis
Introduced in Chapter 6.

ہاں جی *jī hā*

yes

Introduced in Chapter 1.

جوتا *jūtā*

shoe — inherited, and a real cousin of English yoke, and of Sanskrit's own yoga
Introduced in Chapter 14.

کیسی / کیسے *kaise / kaisī*

how — addressing a man / addressing a woman
Introduced in Chapter 4.

کالا *kālā*

black — inherited, but from a root borrowed into Sanskrit itself, and the first color that changes its own ending
Introduced in Chapter 13.

کان *kān*

ear — the first body word since Chapter 4 folded *کیسے آپ* into a single wellbeing check
Introduced in Chapter 10.

خاندان *khāndān*

family — the collective word this chapter's three people-words never needed, and Persian, like every social word Urdu has borrowed so far
Introduced in Chapter 9.

خدا *khudā*

God — the Persian-borrowed half of the standard Urdu farewell
Introduced in Chapter 5.

خدا حافظ *khudā hāfiz*

goodbye — a standard Urdu farewell
Introduced in Chapter 5.

کوٹ *koṭ*

coat — a modern English loan, closing a chapter that showed loans running in both directions
Introduced in Chapter 14.

کیا *kyā*

what
Introduced in Chapter 3.

لال *lāl*

red — Persian, and an adjective that never changes its ending
Introduced in Chapter 13.

لینا *lenā*

to take — a verb worn down to one syllable, and the third job Urdu gives the letter ی
Introduced in Chapter 8.

لکھنا *likhnā*

to write — an inherited verb for an act whose every tool Urdu named in Arabic and Persian
Introduced in Chapter 7.

کرنا مدد *madad karnā*

to help — an Arabic noun plus a native verb, which is the machine Urdu used to swallow two foreign vocabularies whole
Introduced in Chapter 8.

ہوں ... میں *maiñ ... hūñ*

I am ...
Introduced in Chapter 4.

شکریہ ہوں، ٹھیک میں *maiñ ṭhīk hūñ, shukriyā*

I am fine, thank you
Introduced in Chapter 4.

ہے ... نام میرا *merā nām ... hai*

my name is ...
Introduced in Chapter 2.

منہ *muñh*

mouth — the plain نون that already nasalized آنکھ, unglossed, and a Greek word possibly hiding behind the same root
Introduced in Chapter 10.

نہیں *nahĩ*

no / not

Introduced in Chapter 1.

ناک *nāk*

nose — the same three letters as کان, read in reverse, and a real cousin of the English word this time
Introduced in Chapter 10.

نیلا *nīlā*

blue — an honest dead end backward, and the word behind English aniline going forward

Introduced in Chapter 13.

پانی *pānī*

water — the first word you would actually ask for, and a verb from three chapters ago put back to work

Introduced in Chapter 12.

پڑھنا *parhnā*

to read — and to study, and to recite, because it never meant reading silently

Introduced in Chapter 7.

پسند *pasand*

liked, pleasing — a Persian word, not a verb, in the one Urdu sentence that refuses to let you be its subject

Introduced in Chapter 8.

پوچھنا *pūchhnā*

to ask — and the one place where Urdu's inherited half and its Persian half turn out to be the same word

Introduced in Chapter 8.

قمیض *qamīz*

shirt — Arabic, and probably the very same word English borrowed as chemise, by a completely different road

Introduced in Chapter 14.

روٹی *roṭī*

bread — an honest dead end, and پسند put back to work on everything this chapter taught

Introduced in Chapter 12.

سفید *safed*

white — Persian, and a real cousin of English white by the Iranian road, the same shape as دل and ḥṛdaya
Introduced in Chapter 13.

سلام *salām*

hello / peace
Introduced in Chapter 1.

سمجھنا *samajhnā*

to understand — literally to wake up fully, on the root that named the Buddha
Introduced in Chapter 7.

سردی *sardī*

cold — Persian, garmī's opposite, and a hook back through this whole book's two-roads words
Introduced in Chapter 15.

شکریہ *shukriyā*

thank you
Introduced in Chapter 1.

سوچنا *sochnā*

to think — a verb that began as a word for burning and grieving
Introduced in Chapter 7.

ٹھیک *ṭhīk*

fine, well, correct
Introduced in Chapter 4.

ٹوپی *ṭopī*

cap, hat — an honest dead end backward, and the word English borrowed as topee going forward
Introduced in Chapter 14.

Review Questions

Try these without looking ahead. Every prompt comes from the same canonical lesson data as its chapter. Answers begin in the next section.

Chapter 2

2.1 میرا نام ... ہے — *my name is ...*

Type the Urdu sentence 'My name is Sara.'

Chapter 3

3.1 آپ / تم / تو — *three relationships inside "you"*

Type the Urdu 'you' safest in a first meeting.

3.2 کیا — *what*

Type Urdu for 'what'.

3.3 آپ کا نام کیا ہے؟ — *ask a name respectfully*

Type the respectful Urdu question 'What is your name?'

3.4 آپ سے مل خوشی ہوئی — *pleased to meet you*

Type the Urdu response 'Pleased to meet you.'

3.5 Practice — *a complete Urdu name exchange*

After someone asks آپ کا نام کیا ہے؟, type the Urdu answer using Sara.

Chapter 4

4.1 کیسے / کیسی — “how” follows the addressee

Type the Urdu ‘how’ form used when respectfully addressing a woman.

4.2 آپ کیسے ہیں؟ / آپ کیسی ہیں؟ — ask respectfully

Type the respectful Urdu question ‘How are you?’ addressed to a man.

4.3 میں ... ہوں — one frame for “I am ...”

Type the Urdu frame ‘I am ...’, leaving three dots for the state word.

4.4 ٹھیک — “fine,” “well,” and “correct”

Type the Urdu word meaning ‘fine’ or ‘well’.

4.5 میں ٹھیک ہوں، شکریہ — “I am fine, thank you”

Reply in Urdu: ‘I am fine, thank you.’

4.6 Practice — an Urdu wellbeing exchange

After آپ کیسے ہیں؟ type the polite Urdu reply.

Chapter 5

5.1 خدا — the first half of an Urdu farewell

Type the Urdu word khudā, meaning ‘God’.

5.2 حافظ — “guardian” or “protector”

Type the Urdu word hāfiz, meaning ‘guardian’ or ‘protector’.

5.3 خدا حافظ — goodbye

Type the standard Urdu expression for ‘goodbye’.

5.4 Practice — open, check, and close

The short Urdu interaction is ending. Type the final expression.

Chapter 7

7.1 لکھنا — “to write,” with nothing new left to decode

Type the Urdu verb meaning ‘to write’.

Chapter 8

8.1 پسند — *Urdu does not like things; things please Urdu*

Type the Urdu word for 'to me' — the form main takes when it cannot be the subject.

Chapter 9

9.1 بہن — *“sister,” and the word that makes میرا move*

Type the Urdu for 'my sister', choosing the correct form of my.

9.2 خاندان — *“family,” the word your three new nouns never needed*

Type the Urdu word for 'family' — the loan that groups بھائی and بہن together.

Chapter 10

10.1 ناک — *“nose,” the same three letters as کان, backwards*

Type the Urdu word for 'nose' — the same three letters as کان, reversed.

10.2 منہ — *“mouth,” and the آنکھ نون already used without explaining*

Which earlier body word in this chapter also used a plain نون to mark a nasal vowel, unglossed at the time?

Chapter 11

11.1 دل — *“heart,” Persian, and still a cousin of the English word*

Is Urdu دل related to Sanskrit hr̥daya, or is the resemblance a coincidence like پسند and candere?

Chapter 12

12.1 دودھ — *“milk,” and a false friend worth naming before you fall for it*

Which English word is the REAL cousin of دودھ — dough, or doughty?

12.2 روٹی — *“bread,” and پسند closes the chapter*

Type the Urdu sentence 'I like bread.'

Chapter 16

16.1 | — *one stroke, and a page that runs the other way*

Besides running right to left, what else does an Urdu word do as it moves across the page?

16.2 ﺞ — *alif, and then a bowl under the line*

Does the bowl of lām sit on the baseline or below it?

16.3 ﺱ — *three teeth, then a bowl, without lifting*

How many times do you lift the pen while writing sīn?

16.4 ﻡ — *a round head, and a tail under the line*

When mīm is joined into the middle of a word, which part of it survives?

16.5 *Letters that hold hands, and the one that will not*

You see a gap in the middle of an Urdu word. What is the likeliest reason?

16.6 ﻙ — *a bowl with a slash laid over it*

How many times do you lift the pen when writing kāf?

16.7 ﻥ — *a deep bowl, and one dot*

Where does the dot of nūn sit — above the bowl or low inside it?

16.8 ﻱ — *one S-curve, no dots*

How many dots does the standalone ye carry?

16.9 *Practice — eight words you already knew, now read*

Urdu writes its long vowels but leaves the short ones off the page. What does that mean for a word you have never heard?

Answer Key

The first response is the canonical display answer. When a question accepts other authored forms, they appear underneath.

Chapter 2

2.1 میرا نام ... ہے — *my name is ...*

Answer: ہے سارا نام میرا

Also accepted: mera naam Sara hai; merā nām Sārā hai

Chapter 3

3.1 آپ / تم / تو — *three relationships inside “you”*

Answer: آپ

Also accepted: aap; āp

3.2 کیا — *what*

Answer: کیا

Also accepted: kya; kyā

3.3 آپ کا نام کیا ہے؟ — *ask a name respectfully*

Answer: ہے؟ کیا نام کا آپ

Also accepted: آپ کا نام کیا ہے؟; aap ka naam kya hai; āp kā nām kyā hai

3.4 آپ سے مل کر خوشی ہوئی — *pleased to meet you*

Answer: ہوئی خوشی کر مل سے آپ

Also accepted: aap se mil kar khushi hui; āp se mil kar khushī huī

3.5 Practice — a complete Urdu name exchange

Answer: ہے سارا نام میرا

Also accepted: mera naam Sara hai; merā nām Sārā hai

Chapter 4

4.1 کیسی / کیسے — “how” follows the addressee

Answer: کیسی

Also accepted: kaisi; kaisī

4.2 آپ کیسی ہیں؟ / آپ کیسے ہیں؟ — ask respectfully

Answer: ہیں؟ کیسے آپ

Also accepted: آپ کیسے ہیں; aap kaise hain; āp kaise hain

4.3 میں ... ہوں — one frame for “I am ...”

Answer: ہوں ... میں

Also accepted: ہوں --- میں; main ... hun; main ... hūn

4.4 ٹھیک — “fine,” “well,” and “correct”

Answer: ٹھیک

Also accepted: thik; ṭhīk; theek

4.5 میں ٹھیک ہوں، شکریہ — “I am fine, thank you”

Answer: شکریہ ہوں، ٹھیک میں

Also accepted: شکریہ ہوں ٹھیک میں; main thik hun shukriya; main ṭhīk hūn shukriyā

4.6 Practice — an Urdu wellbeing exchange

Answer: شکریہ ہوں، ٹھیک میں

Also accepted: شکریہ ہوں ٹھیک میں; main thik hun shukriya; main ṭhīk hūn shukriyā

Chapter 5

5.1 خدا — the first half of an Urdu farewell

Answer: خدا

Also accepted: khuda; khudā; xuda; xudā

5.2 حافظ — “guardian” or “protector”

Answer: حافظ

Also accepted: hafiz; hāfiz; haafiz; hafez

5.3 حافظ خدا — goodbye

Answer: حافظ خدا

Also accepted: khuda hafiz; khudā hāfiz; xuda hafiz; khudahafiz

5.4 Practice — open, check, and close

Answer: حافظ خدا

Also accepted: khuda hafiz; khudā hāfiz; khudahafiz

Chapter 7

7.1 لکھنا — “to write,” with nothing new left to decode

Answer: لکھنا

Also accepted: likhna; likhnā; likhnaa

Chapter 8

8.1 پسند — Urdu does not like things; things please Urdu

Answer: مجھے

Also accepted: mujhe; mujhe.; mujhay

Chapter 9

9.1 بہن — “sister,” and the word that makes میرا move

Answer: بہن میری

Also accepted: meri bahan; merī bahan

9.2 خاندان — “family,” the word your three new nouns never needed

Answer: خاندان

Also accepted: khandan; khāndān

Chapter 10

10.1 ناک — “nose,” the same three letters as کان, backwards

Answer: ناک

Also accepted: naak; nāk

10.2 **منہ** — “mouth,” and the **آنکھ** *non* already used without explaining

Answer: **آنکھ**

Also accepted: aankh; āṅkh

Chapter 11

11.1 **دل** — “heart,” Persian, and still a cousin of the English word

Answer: related

Also accepted: related, same root; same PIE root; cousins; yes, related

Chapter 12

12.1 **دوڑ** — “milk,” and a false friend worth naming before you fall for it

Answer: doughty

Also accepted: doughty, not dough

12.2 **روٹی** — “bread,” and **پسند** closes the chapter

Answer: **ہے پسند روٹی مجھے**

Also accepted: mujhe roti pasand hai; mujhe rotī pasand hai

Chapter 16

16.1 **|** — one stroke, and a page that runs the other way

Answer: it cascades downward

Also accepted: it goes down; it descends; each letter sits lower; it slopes down to the left; it cascades

16.2 **ل** — alif, and then a bowl under the line

Answer: below it

Also accepted: below; below the line; under the baseline; beneath the line

16.3 **س** — three teeth, then a bowl, without lifting

Answer: 0

Also accepted: none; zero; not at all; no lifts; 0 times

16.4 **م** — a round head, and a tail under the line

Answer: the round head

Also accepted: the head; the round part; the loop; the head, not the tail

16.5 Letters that hold hands, and the one that will not

Answer: a letter that does not join to the left

Also accepted: a non-joining letter; alif or another non-joiner; a letter that only joins on the right; a letter that refuses to join

16.6 ﺝ — *a bowl with a slash laid over it*

Answer: 1

Also accepted: once; one; one lift; 1 time

16.7 ﺞ — *a deep bowl, and one dot*

Answer: low inside it

Also accepted: inside; low inside the bowl; near the baseline; inside the curve; below

16.8 ﺥ — *one S-curve, no dots*

Answer: 0

Also accepted: none; zero; no dots; 0 dots

16.9 Practice — *eight words you already knew, now read*

Answer: you cannot reliably sound it out

Also accepted: you cannot sound it out; you have to have heard it; you cannot be sure of the vowels; reading and listening must grow together

A note on sources

Script descriptions follow Northwestern University’s open Zero Zabar Urdu-alphabet materials. Chapter 4’s wellbeing forms and register contrast, together with Chapter 5’s farewell, follow Michigan State University’s open *Basic Urdu*.

Index

Look up an English meaning, a dedicated language topic, or a chapter topic. Each linked reference opens the chapter where the material is introduced; the focus labels name only explicitly typed lesson sections.

A

air, wind — Persian, and Persian’s own loan from Arabic, a loan of a loan rather than two roads from one root /هوا/ (hawā)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 15, p. 93

Ask and Answer Names

chapter topic; Chapter 3, p. 9

B

black — inherited, but from a root borrowed into Sanskrit itself, and the first color that changes its own ending /क/ (kāḷā)

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 13, p. 77

blue — an honest dead end backward, and the word behind

English aniline going forward /نیل/ (nīlā)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 13, p. 77

bread — an honest dead end, and /پسند/ put back to work on

everything this chapter taught /روٹی/ (roṭī)

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 12, p. 71

brother — the first noun this book has taught with a real

grammatical gender, and a genuine English cousin /بھائی/ (bhāī)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 9, p. 53

C

cap, hat — an honest dead end backward, and the word English borrowed as topee going forward ٹوپي (ṭopī)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 14, p. 85

coat — a modern English loan, closing a chapter that showed

loans running in both directions کوٹ (koṭ)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 14, p. 85

cold — Persian, garmī's opposite, and a hook back through this whole book's two-roads words سردی (sardī)

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 15, p. 93

E

ear — the first body word since Chapter 4 folded ہیں؟ کیسے آپ into a single wellbeing check کان (kān)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 10, p. 61

eye — a fifth base letter for the two-eyed he, and another real

cousin of an English word آنکھ (āṅkh)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 10, p. 61

F

family — the collective word this chapter's three people-words never needed, and Persian, like every social word Urdu has

borrowed so far خاندان (khāndān)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 9, p. 53

fine, well, correct ٹھیک (ṭhīk)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 4, p. 15

Five Verbs at the Core

chapter topic; Chapter 6, p. 27

Four Colors

chapter topic; Chapter 13, p. 77

Four Things You Wear

chapter topic; Chapter 14, p. 85

Four Verbs Between People

chapter topic; Chapter 8, p. 43

Four Verbs of the Mind

chapter topic; Chapter 7, p. 35

Four Words on the Face

chapter topic; Chapter 10, p. 61

friend — a Persian word that refuses to pick a gender, and exactly the relationship **دوست** (dost) was made for

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 9, p. 53

G**Give your name**

chapter topic; Chapter 2, p. 7

God — the Persian-borrowed half of the standard Urdu

farewell **خدا** (khudā)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 5, p. 23

goodbye — a standard Urdu farewell **حافظ خدا** (khudā hāfiz)

explicit focus: script, grammar; Chapter 5, p. 23

Greetings and responses

chapter topic; Chapter 1, p. 1

guardian, protector — the Arabic-rooted half of the

farewell **حافظ** (hāfiz)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 5, p. 23

H

heart — Persian, and a real cousin of English heart by the

Iranian road, not the Sanskrit one **دل** (dil)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 11, p. 67

heat — Persian, from the same PIE root as Greek thermós, with

English warm only a disputed distant cousin **گرمی** (garmī)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 15, p. 93

hello / peace **سلام** (salām)

Chapter 1, p. 1

how — addressing a man / addressing a woman **کیسی / کیسے** (kaise / kaisī)

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 4, p. 15

How Are You?

chapter topic; Chapter 4, p. 15

How are you? — respectfully to a man / woman آپ / ہیں؟ کیسے آپ

کیسی (āp kaise haiñ? / āp kaisī haiñ?)
explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 4, p. 15

I

I am ... میں ... ہوں (main ... hūñ)
explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 4, p. 15

I am fine, thank you میں ٹھیک ہوں، شکریہ (main ṭhīk hūñ, shukriyā)
explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 4, p. 15

L

Letters that hold hands, and the one that will not

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 16, p. 101

liked, pleasing — a Persian word, not a verb, in the one Urdu

sentence that refuses to let you be its subject پسند (pasand)
explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 8, p. 43

M

milk — a sixth letter learns to breathe, and an English cousin

that is NOT the word you'd guess دودھ (dūdh)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 12, p. 71

mouth — the plain نون **that already nasalized** آنکھ, unglossed, and
a Greek word possibly hiding behind the same root منہ (muñh)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 10, p. 61

my name is ... ہے ... نام میرا (merā nām ... hai)

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 2, p. 7

N

no / not نہیں (nahī)

explicit focus: script, grammar; Chapter 1, p. 1

nose — the same three letters as **کان**, read in reverse, and a real
cousin of the English word this time **ناک** (nāk)
 explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 10, p. 61

P

People You'd Introduce

chapter topic; Chapter 9, p. 53

pleased to meet you **ہوئی خوشی کر مل سے آپ** (āp se mil kar khushī huī)
 explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 3, p. 9

R

rain — Persian, built from “load” plus a noun-forming ending,
and a dead end behind that **بارش** (bārish)
 explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 15, p. 93

Rain, Sun, Wind, Heat, Cold

chapter topic; Chapter 15, p. 93

red — Persian, and an adjective that never changes its
ending **لال** (lāl)
 explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 13, p. 77

S

Seven Letters, and the Words You Already Knew

chapter topic; Chapter 16, p. 101

shirt — Arabic, and probably the very same word English

borrowed as chemise, by a completely different road **قمیض** (qamīz)
 explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 14, p. 85

shoe — inherited, and a real cousin of English yoke, and of
Sanskrit's own yoga **जुता** (jūtā)
 explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 14, p. 85

sister — feminine, where **بھائی** was masculine, and the reason **میرا**
has to change shape **بہن** (bahan)
 explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 9, p. 53

sunshine — inherited, and another honest dead end, like **کان** and
روٹی before it **دھوپ** (dhūp)
 explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 15, p. 93

T

Take Leave

chapter topic; Chapter 5, p. 23

tea — Persian again, this time by an overland road from**Chinese, and the hamza-ye letter's second word چائے (chāy)**

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 12, p. 71

thank you شکریہ (shukriyā)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

The Heart

chapter topic; Chapter 11, p. 67

to ask — and the one place where Urdu's inherited half and its**Persian half turn out to be the same word پوچھنا (pūchhnā)**

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 8, p. 43

to be — and the ending every Urdu verb wears when you name**it ہونا (honā)**

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 6, p. 27

to come — literally “go toward,” built from a prefix and the verb**for going آنا (ānā)**

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 6, p. 27

to go — the verb that shows the two agreements an Urdu**present tense makes at once جانا (jānā)**

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 6, p. 27

to help — an Arabic noun plus a native verb, which is the**machine Urdu used to swallow two foreign vocabularies whole** مر**کرنا (madad karnā)**

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 8, p. 43

to know — the Urdu cousin of English know, Latin notice, and**Greek gnosis جانتا (jānnā)**

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 6, p. 27

to read — and to study, and to recite, because it never meant**reading silently پڑھنا (parhnā)**

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 7, p. 35

to speak — the plain Indo-Aryan verb under Urdu's Persian and**Arabic finery بولنا (bolnā)**

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 6, p. 27

to take — a verb worn down to one syllable, and the third job**Urdu gives the letter لینا (lenā)**

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 8, p. 43

to think — a verb that began as a word for burning and**grieving سوچنا (sochnā)**

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 7, p. 35

to understand — literally to wake up fully, on the root that

named the Buddha سمجھنا (samajhnā)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 7, p. 35

to write — an inherited verb for an act whose every tool Urdu

named in Arabic and Persian لکھنا (likhnā)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 7, p. 35

W

Water, Tea, Milk, Bread

chapter topic; Chapter 12, p. 71

water — the first word you would actually ask for, and a verb

from three chapters ago put back to work پانی (pānī)

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 12, p. 71

what کیا (kyā)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 3, p. 9

What is your name? (respectful) آپ کا نام کیا ہے؟ (āp kā nām kyā hai?)

explicit focus: script; Chapter 3, p. 9

white — Persian, and a real cousin of English white by the

Iranian road, the same shape as دل and ہرِدا (safed)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 13, p. 77

Y

yes جی ہاں (jī hā)

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 1, p. 1

you — respectful / familiar / intimate آپ / تم / تو (āp / tum / tū)

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 9

Other

| — one stroke, and a page that runs the other way

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 16, p. 101

س — three teeth, then a bowl, without lifting

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 16, p. 101

ش ر ک — **three shapes, then stop**

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 1, p. 1

ل — **alif, and then a bowl under the line**

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 16, p. 101

م — **a round head, and a tail under the line**

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 16, p. 101

ن — **a deep bowl, and one dot**

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 16, p. 101

ک — **a bowl with a slash laid over it**

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 16, p. 101

ی — **one S-curve, no dots**

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 16, p. 101